

Free Indeed!

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 20. Dec 4/17 (ns) 2021 Great Martyr Barbara

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http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-020_2021-12-17.doc http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-020_2021-12-17.pdf

Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter at least twice each month. This is the 17th sent to 85 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Contact Info

Patriarch Joseph the All-Comely Texas ORTHODOX Prison Ministry

<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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Questions about the Genealogy of Christ (Mat 1:1-17)

QUESTION 1 Why is the genealogy in the first chapter of Matthew of Joseph, since he was only the foster father of Christ? Or, as St John Chrysostom puts it:

“But whence is it manifest that He is of David?’ one may say. For if He was not sprung of a man, but from a woman only, and the Virgin hath not her genealogy traced, how shall we know that He was of David's race? Thus, there are two things inquired; both why His mother's genealogy is

not recited, and wherefore it can be that Joseph is mentioned by them, who hath no part in the birth: since the latter seems to be superfluous, and the former a defect." (Chrysostom - Homilies on Matthew, Homily 2. Section 7)

QUESTION 2 "Abraham begat Isaac, and Isaac begat Jacob, and Jacob begat Judas and his brethren" (Matthew 1:2)
Who was the mother of Isaac?
Why was Isaac so named?

QUESTION 3 What is Isaac a "type" of?

QUESTION 4 "Abraham begat Isaac, and Isaac begat Jacob, and Jacob begat Judas and his brethren" (Matthew 1:2)
Who is the mother of Jacob?
Who were Jacob's wives? How did he obtain them?
The Great Canon of St Andrew of Crete attaches an important symbolic meaning to Jacobs's two wives. What do they represent?

QUESTION 5 "Abraham begat Isaac, and Isaac begat Jacob, and Jacob begat Judas and his brethren" (Matthew 1:2)
Who was the mother of Judas (or Judah)(who is in the line of Christ?)
Who was the second to the youngest of Judah's brethren? He is also an important "type."

QUESTION 6 "And Judas begat Phares and Zara of Tamar;" (Matthew 1:3)
What was Judas' and Tamar's relationship? Tell the circumstances of the conception. The even more important and marvelous circumstances of the birth of Phares and Zara are discussed in the next question.

QUESTION 7 "And Judas begat Phares and Zara of Tamar;" (Matt 1:3)
Tell the story of Phares and Zara. How were they conceived? What is the theological significance of the way they were born?

QUESTION 8 "And Salmon begat Boaz of Rachab, and Boaz begat Obed of Ruth; and Obed begat Jesse;" (Matthew 1:5)
What sort of woman was Rachab?
Tell the important story associated with her.

QUESTION 9 "And Salmon begat Boaz of Rachab, and Boaz begat Obed of Ruth; and Obed begat Jesse;" (Matthew 1:5)
Who was Ruth? Tell of her life previous to meeting Boaz.
What might we glean from her marriage to Boaz?

QUESTION 10 "And Jesse begat David the king, and David the king begat Solomon of her that had been the wife of Urias;" (Matthew 1:6)
Who was the former wife of Urias?
Why did she conceive a son by David?

Questions about the parable of the Great Supper

QUESTION 1 The parable of the Great Supper closely precedes an important feast. When is the parable read? Why?

QUESTION 2 This parable was uttered in response to something a man said to Jesus. What was it?

QUESTION 3 "A certain man made a great supper." (Luke 14:16)
Who is the man? What is the significance of this?

QUESTION 4 What is the supper? Why a great supper and not a dinner?

QUESTION 5 "A certain man made a great supper, and bade many: And sent his servant at suppertime to say to them that were bidden, Come; for all things are now ready." (Luke 14:16b-17)
Who is the servant? Note the two callings ("to say to them that were bidden"). What is the meaning of this?

QUESTION 6 "And they all with one consent began to make excuse. The first said unto him, I have bought a piece of ground, and I must needs go and see it: I pray thee have me excused. And another said, I have bought five yoke of oxen, and I go to prove them: I pray thee have me excused." (14:18,19)

What does the ground and the 5 yoke of oxen represent? Does the number of oxen have any special meaning?

QUESTION 7 "And another said, I have married a wife, and therefore I cannot come." (Luke 14:20)
What is the meaning?

QUESTION 8 The ones who rejected the invitation to the Great Supper must be understood in 2 ways. Who are these people?

QUESTION 9 So that servant came, and shewed his lord these things. Then the master of the house being angry said to his servant, Go out quickly into the streets and lanes of the city, and bring in hither the poor, and the maimed, and the halt, and the blind. (Luke 14:21)
Who are these people? Describe their afflictions and character.

QUESTION 10 "And the Lord said unto the servant, Go out into the highways and hedges, and compel them to come in, that my house may be filled." (Luke 14:24)
Who are the people in the highways and hedges? What are these places?

Questions about the Gospel of Matthew Chapter 2

QUESTION 1 Now when Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judaea in the days of Herod the king, behold, there came wise men from the east to Jerusalem ... [Mat 2:1]
What does Bethlehem mean? Why is this name apropos?

QUESTION 2 Now when Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judaea in the days of Herod the king, behold, there came wise men from the east to Jerusalem ... [Mat 2:1]

Why does Matthew mention Herod? Hint - this has to do with Herod's ethnic origins and a very important prophesy.

QUESTION 3 Now when Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judaea in the days of Herod the king, behold, there came wise men from the east to Jerusalem ... [Mat 2:1]
Why did the Magi come? Why did they mention a star?

QUESTION 4 Now when Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judaea in the days of Herod the king, behold, there came wise men from the east to Jerusalem ... [Mat 2:1]

What does the coming of the Magi forefigure?

QUESTION 5 "Saying, Where is he that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him." [Mat 2:2]

There are many types of stars in the heavens. Our sun is a small star. Other stars are red giants, white dwarfs, etc. Discuss the nature of the star the Magi saw, and cite verses in Matthew's gospel to support your opinion.

QUESTION 6 "Saying, Where is he that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him." [Mat 2:2]

Why did the Magi stop in their journey and inquire of Herod? Give two reasons.

QUESTION 7 When Herod the king had heard these things, he was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him. [Mat 2:3]

Why was Herod troubled?

QUESTION 8 "And they said unto him, In Bethlehem of Judaea: for thus it is written by the prophet, And thou Bethlehem, in the land of Juda, art not the least among the princes of Juda: for out of thee shall come a Governor, that shall rule my people Israel." [Mat 2:5]

Which prophet? Is the quote they gave Herod absolutely accurate? Speculate why.

QUESTION 9 And thou Bethlehem, in the land of Juda, art not the least among the princes of Juda: for out of thee shall come a Governor, that shall rule my people Israel. [Mat 2:6]

What does the prophet mean by "...out of thee shall come A Governor"?

QUESTION 10 "And when they were come into the house, they saw the young child with Mary his mother, and fell down, and worshipped him: and when they had opened their treasures, they presented unto him gifts; gold, and frankincense, and myrrh." [Mat 2:11]

What does this verse tell us about the timing of the veneration of the Magi? In other words, did they venerate the Lord on the day of His birth?

QUESTION 11 "And when they were come into the house, they saw the young child with Mary his mother, and fell down, and worshipped him: and when they had opened their treasures, they presented unto him gifts; gold, and frankincense, and myrrh." [Mat 2:11]

What are the symbolic meanings of the gifts of the Magi?

QUESTION 12 "And being warned of God in a dream that they should not return to Herod, they departed into their own country another way." [Mat 2:12]

There is almost always outer and inner meanings to scripture, and this verse is not an exception. Elucidate both meanings.

QUESTION 13 "And when they were departed, behold, the angel of the Lord appeareth to Joseph in a dream, saying, Arise, and take the young child and his mother, and flee into Egypt, and be thou there until I bring thee word: for Herod will seek the young child to destroy him. {14} When he arose, he took the young child and his mother by night, and departed into Egypt: {15} And was there until the death of Herod: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, Out of Egypt have I called my son." [Mat 2:13-15]

How did the flight into Egypt fulfill TWO prophecies?

QUESTION 14 "Then Herod, when he saw that he was mocked of the wise men, was exceeding wroth, and sent forth, and slew all the children that were in Bethlehem, and in all the coasts thereof, from two years old and under, according to the time which he had diligently inquired of the wise men." [Mat 2:16]

Why did Herod pick this time period?

QUESTION 15 "Then was fulfilled that which was spoken by Jeremy the prophet, saying, {18} In Rama was there a voice heard, lamentation, and weeping, and great mourning, Rachel weeping for her children, and would not be comforted, because they are not." [Mat 2:17-18]

Rachel is both a metaphor, and a historical reference, and Ramah is a metaphor. Explain.

QUESTION 16 "But when Herod was dead, behold, an angel of the Lord appeareth in a dream to Joseph in Egypt, {20} Saying, Arise, and take the young child and his mother, and go into the land of Israel: for they are dead which sought the young child's life. {21} And he arose, and took the young child and his mother, and came into the land of Israel. {22} But when he heard that Archelaus did reign in Judaea in the room of his father Herod, he was afraid to go thither: notwithstanding, being warned of God in a dream, he turned aside into the parts of Galilee: {23} And he came and dwelt in a city called Nazareth: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophets, He shall be called a Nazarene." [Mat 2:19-23]

What is peculiar about this prophesy, and how we may infer that it is genuine?

Prison Ministry News

2021 Prison Ministry Field Report from Priest David Companik of St. Jonah Orthodox Church (Spring, TX):

By God's grace, and in collaboration with Fr. Seraphim Holland of St. Nicholas Orthodox Church in McKinney, TX and St. Joseph the All-Comely Texas Prison Ministry, the field ministry, correspondence, and resource distribution efforts have grown this year.

4 Active Programs on Unit (led by Fr. David Companik):

- **Luther Unit** (Twice a Month, 1st and 3rd Saturdays) in Navasota, TX - Restarted March 2021. 9 regular attendees, including 7 baptized members. Book & Bible Study with prayer.

- **Wynne Unit** (Twice a Month, 1st & 3rd Mondays) in Huntsville, TX - Restarted April 2021. 14 regular attendees, including 5 baptized members and 5 catechumens. Book & Bible Study with a full Service (Canon, Akathist, Moleben, etc.)
- **Boyd Unit** (Once a Month, 4th Tuesday) in Teague, TX - Newly Established November 2021. Book & Bible Study with a full Service (Canon, Akathist, Moleben, etc.)
- **Estelle Unit** (Once a Month, 1st Monday) in Huntsville, TX - Restarted December 2021. 8 regular attendees, including 1 baptized member and 1 catechumen. Book & Bible Study with prayer.

2 Pending Programs (to be led by Fr. David and/or Fr. Seraphim Holland) [Awaiting Unit Approval]

- **Hughes Unit** in Gatesville, TX
- **Michael Unit** in Tennessee Colony, TX

Pastoral Visits Made to 20 Locations/23 Souls Across the State (and Oklahoma) since March 2021

- We are always in need of donations to OCPM Houston to cover the priests' travel expenses, both for pastoral visits and regular programs.

Monthly Newsletter - 90+ Recipients - Funded and Distributed by St. Joseph the All-Comely Texas Prison Ministry

Fr. Seraphim Holland is the editor and principal writer, producing a monthly newsletter that includes Commentary on Scripture and the Great Feasts, Lives of Saints, Pastoral Reflections, and more. This newsletter has been a great encouragement and inspiration to its growing readership, as well as an excellent form of catechism.

Monthly Typika Service Mailout - 47 Recipients (Fr. David)

This mailout provides inmates with the reader service texts for Sundays and Feast Days so that they can pray the Typika Service in place of Divine Liturgy. It is funded through St. Jonah's annual prison ministry budget + donations. A few Orthodox volunteers regularly assist with the mailout: folding, stuffing/stamping envelopes, etc.

Correspondence

Year to date, Fr David has responded to **180 letters**. Correspondents are steadily growing as more imprisoned souls learn about Orthodoxy and write our ministry. JPay.com continues to be the main platform for sending letters, reaching inmates within 24-48 hours.

Orthodox Bibles, Books, & Resources Provided to the Imprisoned

Through the combined resources of OCPM Houston and St. Jonah's, we put to good use upwards of \$4,000 this year alone on the cost of purchasing and distributing (in person and by mail) numerous books and resources, including bibles, prayer books, paper icons, church calendars, and more.

Now Open: St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Mission (ROCOR) and Re-Entry Home (Future Halfway House) in Marshall, TX (1100 North Franklin Marshall Texas 75670) <https://stjosephtheallcomely.life/>

Fr. Seraphim is the rector and serves Divine Liturgy at the mission parish twice a month in the downstairs worship space; once a month, the parishioners/residents travel to McKinney, TX to attend St. Nicholas.

We are starting with humble beginnings and can currently have 1 parolee at a time and hope to expand.

Volunteer legal aid is greatly needed in order to identify and complete the next steps to establish a TDCJ-approved halfway house, which would allow more than 1 parolee to live on site in Marshall.

- **As our ministry grows, we keep running up against legal questions and hurdles - attorneys and paralegals, please lend us your expertise!**

- Additionally, donations are needed to cover the monthly mortgage and operating costs. This is in the range of \$1,000/month.

At present, this cost is paid for out of the St. Joseph the All-Comely Texas Prison Ministry funds administered by St. Nicholas Church. We will "hit a wall" eventually. We are looking for monthly donations to cover our costs to have funds to get our parolees established. It is all very complicated for a parolee in a community environment to have outside work. The greatest asset that we can provide to these men is community life and prayerful support, and friendship. The greatest enemy of the parolee will is anxiety and confusion and difficulty adjusting, and our community life is the best chance to alleviate that toxic and dangerous emotional state.

It is very difficult (almost impossible!) to have an active community life with active prayer in the morning and evening if people have all kinds of outside jobs. We're hoping very much to provide employment with welding and some other industries

Thank you for your attention and prayerful support.

Glory to God for all things!

With love in the Lord,

Fr. David, Fr Seraphim

Prison Ministry trip report. Our goal is holiness.

Entrance of the Theotokos, Nov 21/Dec 4, 2021

(The following is edited from a recording I made as I was driving back from Marshall, TX)

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/prison-report_2021-12-4+the-goal-is-holiness.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/prison-report_2021-12-4+the-goal-is-holiness.doc

For the first time in the parole house, we celebrated a Great Feast, the "Entrance of the Mother of God." And I was delighted, although it was just Michael and myself, and we missed Jude Thaddaeus terribly. And, of course, we also missed our former resident terribly. We are still adjusting to the loss. All three of us worked very hard and spent a lot of money, time, and blood (effort, with all of our heart) to make a home for someone who needed it. Our hospitality was rejected without thinking about what we had

done or what we were trying to do, but only excuses and gaslighting. It leaves a big hole.

We need to buck up and get over it because this is the way life is. The fact is that there is no lock on the door, and everything we do is based on promises made to each other. Those of us running the house, myself, Jude Thaddeus, and Michael, can choose to be honest with each other and keep our promises regardless of what anyone else does.

It was very cathartic to be able to celebrate the services together. It was simple because I sing simply, and Michael is just learning to sing, but we sang the entire vigil, all of Vespers, all of the Litia service, all of Matins, and the First Hour. It took us about two and a half hours. We made a few allowances for our humble situation. I only censed once even though the service called for it multiple times. We said the prayers for Litia (this is a service between Vespers and Matins when we sing some beautiful hymns and then say some very compunctionate petitions addressed to our Lord Jesus Christ and invoking the prayers of the saints, and then bless some bread, wine, oil, and wheat berries). Because I didn't bring any of the

necessary foods, we omitted the blessing of them. The following day, we served Divine Liturgy at the bracing hour of 7 o'clock.

In life, the idea of things is easier than the things themselves. The idea of having a prison ministry and helping people get out of prison and rebuild their lives is wonderful! In practice, it is extremely difficult and is fraught with lots of failures, but with our patience cooperating with God's help, some succeed, and we're going to be able to find some that succeed. So, we have to stay with it.

One of the biggest problems of people in prison is that they absorb what the psychologists call "learned helplessness." It takes this form with them. Basically, no matter what they do, everything is terrible in their life. Usually, it was chaotic before prison. After they are in prison, they observe that honesty, kindness, or keeping promises often do not help their cause and sometimes even bring punishment and suffering. They live with the expectation that things do not work out unless they, as the clichés go, "stand their ground," and "take care of business," and "look out for themselves." Many situations elicit immediate white-hot anxiety. The typical reaction to anxiety in prison is to do "whatever is necessary" according to their deluded beliefs of what is necessary, to survive.

If we live our lives expecting things not to work out, they don't work out. We must live as "eternal optimists," even while being at the same time, realistic that in prison ministry, most of the time things don't work out, whether you're visiting people in prison or whether you have a parole or halfway house. Most of the time, people can't deal with their (shall we say, "demons") with that bad thinking that they constantly have in their head.

They can't understand that "Penitentiary Honesty" doesn't work in the world, and it does not even work in the penitentiary. This type of honesty is very flexible ethics; if honesty works, use it; if something else is needed, use that. The trouble with this fungible ethical view is that it becomes hard to know what is true and what isn't, and a person begins to believe his lies and no longer believe that they are lies but are the truth. And, when they're stressed, they go back to things they know, even if they were maladaptive things, even if there are things that got them in prison or broke up relationships in the past, etc.

All of those things that people go back to are to alleviate their anxiety. There is drug abuse or other dangerous or sinful behaviors in extreme cases. I think it's probably pretty rare for an ex-smoker not to become a current smoker when they come out of prison. They also use destructive coping mechanisms, like outright lying or revising the truth in such a way that they actually believe their revisions, and intense emotions that mask their anxiety or relieve it by distracting them, such as anger, judging, conversations in their head, gaslighting, etc.

The fact is that you can't know a person until you've lived with them a while, until you've seen what they are really like, and not what they have promised. You can only see what a person is like if they go through stressful situations or personal disagreements. You must see people when they are tried and tested by fire, as silver is tried in the fire, to see if what they said is what they're able to do or what they actually wanted. (Psalm 11:6 "The words of the Lord are pure words, silver that is fired, tried in the earth, brought to sevenfold purity.")

A person must want sobriety to be sober. I'm not talking about sobriety from alcohol or drugs. I'm talking about sobriety from those thoughts in our head that command our attention and delude us. When we live in our head, it is full of delusional thinking. We all have these delusional thoughts, and we must find a way to resist them when they attack us. If you listen to your thoughts, you don't have a chance because your thoughts will always lead you astray, and the demons are always involved in making suggestions. And your thoughts in your head will never second-guess you and never correct you, and you're never going to do well.

And that is a big problem with people coming out of prison. It's a big problem in the world, everywhere, but in prison, that kind of thinking is entirely normal and acceptable. When there are thoughts in our head that are unchecked, and anytime someone says that they are "standing their ground," or "keeping it real," or "doing what they need to survive," they are actually running away, living in a fantasy, and thinking that they are living, but actually "living" in a way that is dying. Your thoughts, and my thoughts, and everyone's thoughts, will always lead us to ruin if they are not evaluated by prayer, and the stirrings of the heart, and if we do not seek counsel that we are willing to trust.

We're trying to teach people not to run away and to confront their anxieties and their regrets in life, and to make something out of their life, to find the church, and to live with holiness.

My sermon on the occasion of the "Entry of the Mother of God" was mostly about holiness because, of course, one thinks about holiness when contemplating the Mother of God. The Entrance is a quiet feast that emphasizes the process by which the Mother of God became holy. It's one that very few people understand. Probably more than half of Orthodox Christians do not even know this feast exists, and even if they do know about it, it's not even a blip on their radar. It's a beautiful feast though, because it shows that holiness has to be cultivated.

The Mother of God didn't just drop down from the sky. God didn't just make her holy like some sort of robot. She had holy parents who prayed for her and dedicated her to the Lord. There were generations upon generations of refinements of human nature for Joachim and Anna to pray for a child and dedicate this holy child to the Lord. And in the third year of this child's life, of course, she was then brought to the temple. She then had more seasoning and the experience of holiness by living in the temple. She spent most of her day living in the holy of holies, being ministered to by an angel, and remaining fully in prayer. From the holy of holies, she heard all the prophecies (many of which were about her) when they were read in temple services, and she ate heavenly food from an angel. All of those things contributed to her becoming holy.

Of course, she had a temperament that would accept this holiness and longed for it, but it wasn't just injected into her. It became organically part of her because she accepted it.

And that's what we have to have in this house. I don't want to be arrogant and consider anything we are doing to be holy like the Mother of God is holy, but basically, everything we do in life should be an attempt to become holy and do things in a holy way.

And in our prison ministry house, we're trying to give a place for people to go to because it's very hard sometimes for a prisoner to find a place to parole, and halfway houses are like "devil's islands." We want to give people a "leg up," help them get a job and get started, encourage them, and help them deal with their anxieties, adjustment problems, etc. The most positive indicator for success for a person on parole is community support.

We want to do all those such things. We are trying to do these practical things: we want to give people an excellent opportunity to make the best of it. At the core of what we are trying to do is live in a holy way and have that holiness help others in the house. And then those people live in a holy manner and bring their holiness out and affect the world. That's at the core of what we want to do in our prison ministry.

If we had a slogan, like companies have slogans, perhaps the best one would be: "Become Holy." That's the purpose of our life; it is to become holy. The purpose of prison ministry is to become holy. The purpose of me traveling to Marshall every other week and Fr David traveling to prisons every week is for everyone we influence (including ourselves) to become holy. We have practical concerns, challenges, successes, and failures, but all that actually matters is that we become holy.

When Michael and I celebrated the holy service commemorating the "Entry of the Mother of God," we got our bearings again; the pop-culture way to say this would be that we had an "attitude adjustment." We got knocked around by our last resident leaving so abruptly, and so much about our last conversation was unpleasant in the extreme. He not only left the house, but he also left all of the Orthodox materials that he owned - icons and Bibles and books and prayer books and the Psalter. It was all left behind, whereas it was apparently very important to him for his salvation three weeks before. It was healing and empowering for us to remember what we really are doing here and that our ministry to him does not need to stop because he has stopped.

And, of course, we're not trying to keep anybody from leaving, and everyone in the universe can run away, whether it's from a promise, or responsibility, or something that makes them anxious, or just something that they don't want to do. That's the big temptation that comes with freedom. Freedom can be abused, especially when there has been trauma. Everybody has had trauma. The first inclination when something triggers our trauma is to run. We must fight that inclination.

St. Joseph the All Comely Prison Ministry is not running away. That never does anything for you. When you run away, all you do is bring yourself to another place, but you haven't changed anything because all the wrong stuff is still wrong in your head. And if somehow things can be in your heart, they can influence your head. Then it doesn't matter where you are. You're not going to prosper.

We are not running. I am able to promise that, but I'm not able to promise that I will not think about it once in a while. But if I think about it, it's just demonic thoughts trying to trick me. What are we going to do? We're going to celebrate the services. We're going to be a community waiting for another person to come, and maybe another one after that, and another one after that. For any of that to happen, we must be here. I'll go out here every two weeks; we'll celebrate the services. We will do yard work, raise chickens, and try to learn to weld. We'll do whatever we do, but in the midst of all that, the main job we're going to do is to try to be holy.

Priest Seraphim Holland

The unimpeachable religious and ethical value of the story of Jesus

The unimpeachable religious and ethical value of the story of Jesus is that it tells us what love looks like. Love, considered abstractly, is a pretty vague concept. It isn't nearly so abstract when a man who is an itinerant Jewish rabbi and carpenter, abandons everything to go hang out with the poor, the ill, the downtrodden, and the despised - without rejecting either kindness or the hospitality of the wealthy - and insisted on his followers being good to everyone (even Samaritan and Romans) because that is what God is like.

Who castigates the religious authorities for abandoning their task of loving and serving God while getting lost in trivialities as they fleece the poor in the name of religion.

Who forgives everyone their personal sins if they are repentant - but authoritatively demands that each and every one of them "go and do not sin again, lest something worse befall you".

Who does good and unflinchingly marches into Jerusalem to confront the religious and political authorities of his society, offending both by causing a disturbance and forcibly cleaning the temple of the money-changers and usurers who had set up in the only part of the temple accessible to women and converts - knowing beforehand what this would cost him.

In short, love is like a man who does what is good and gets killed for it, refusing to change course even in the face of certain death, even when he is abandoned by his friends, even when he is tortured...accepting the personal failure of it all by graciously forgiving them anyway on his instrument of torture at the moment of his death. That's what love looks like.

That's the kind of selfless and disinterested love that cannot be killed - the kind of love that a just God exhumes and revives on principle.

If there really is a God who loves like that - if Christ was the Son of God that He claimed to be - then this should have certain implications for those of us who follow Christ, and this includes our relationship to the specific moral instructions that he provided to his followers. To say that love is "like Christ" is to say something rather specific. To ditch the particularity and simply say that God is love (however one might imagine it or prefer it to look like) ... this is perhaps a little less specific and subject to interpretation. It is abstractly true, in that it is a kind of tautology: God=Love; Love=God. But it isn't very informative, and it can lead us to project our own misunderstanding of love onto God. Religious people can make the same mistake - but we have to deal with the story, and that serves as a kind of corrective for us if we let it. Priest Cassian Sibley

NB:Gleanings for the Holy Fathers

"NB" is an abbreviation for the fancy Latin phrase: "note well." It is undoubtedly important to "note well" holy things. This abbreviation is used in a lot of social media.

How mistaken are those people who seek happiness outside of themselves, in foreign lands and journeys, in riches and glory, in great possessions and pleasures, in diversions and vain things, which have a bitter end! In the same thing to construct the tower of happiness outside of ourselves as it is to build a house in a place that is consistently shaken by earthquakes. Happiness is found within ourselves, and blessed is the man who has understood this. Happiness is a pure heart, for such a heart becomes the throne of God. Thus says Christ of those who have pure hearts: "I will visit them and will walk in them, and I will be a God to them, and they will be my people." (11 Cor. 6:16) What can be lacking to them? Nothing, nothing at all! For they have the greatest good in their hearts: God Himself! St. Nektarios of Aegina

"There is no need to weep much over the destruction of a church; after all, each of us, according to God's mercy, has or should have his own church-the heart; go in there and pray, as much as you have strength and time. If this church is not well made and is abandoned (without inward prayer), then the visible church will be of little benefit." Letter of Archbishop Barlaam to Abbess M.

Ignore what they are telling you when they wrong you. Instead, pray to God that He will give a good Angel to them, and peace of mind to you.

Once you make your peace with everyone and wish everyone well, then nothing will torment you.

Otherwise, we torture and destroy ourselves mentally and physically, we get sick, and all because we failed to overcome our negative thinking. At

which point it gets much harder for us to come back to our senses.

Archimandrite Thaddeus of Vitovnica.

"The priests are bad, the state is not good, everything is bad. You would like to have the Holy Queen Tamara as president & St. Nicholas the Wonderworker to serve in your parish. And what about you - what are you really like? Who are you?" *St. Gabriel Urgebazde*

"Parents always want their children to be happy, content and thankful for them for all their work and sacrifice. So when they see their children in a bad mood and unthankful, they're saddened. It's the same with our Heavenly Father. He has given us everything, but we are always unsatisfied and gloomy. Instead of thanking and praising God for everything, we only express our thankfulness with our lips, and our hearts remain cold. Joy is thankfulness, and when we are joyful, that is the best expression of thanks we can offer the Lord, Who delivers us from sorrow and sin." — *Elder Thaddeus of Vitovnica*

EVERYONE SEES WHAT THEY WANT TO SEE

November 15th, 2021 marks the 12th anniversary of the blissful repose of His Holiness Serbian Patriarch Pavle (1914-2009).

In the patriarchate, they often recall a dialogue between Patriarch Pavle and the deacon who accompanied him everywhere. They needed to get to a church in Banovo Brdo where the Patriarch was to serve. "How are we going there? By car?" asked the deacon, prompting the answer. "By bus" was the Patriarch's decisive reply. It was a warm morning hinting at a hot day, and the deacon was apparently reluctant to go by public transport. So he tried to reason the Patriarch out of going by bus: "It's a long way.. it's very stuffy on a crowded bus..." "We are going by bus!" firmly insisted His Holiness, taking the road and resolutely tapping his staff on the pavement.

Following behind, the deacon offered another, irrefragable as it seemed to him, argument: "Your Holiness, it's summer time, many are going to Ada Ciganlija (a beach in Belgrade) to bathe, the buses are full of scantily clad passengers... It's not right..." His Holiness stopped for a moment, turned to his assistant and said: "You know, father, everyone sees what they want to see!"

"Christians, have we understood the great responsibility that we have taken on before God through baptism? Have we come to know that we must conduct ourselves as children of God, that we must align our will with the will of God, that we must remain free from sin, that we must love God with all our hearts and always patiently await union with Him? Have we thought about the fact that our heart should be so filled with love that it should overflow to our neighbor? Do we have the feeling that we must become holy and perfect, children of God and heirs of the Kingdom of Heaven? We must struggle for this, so that we may not be shown unworthy and rejected. Let none of us lose our boldness, nor neglect our duties, nor be afraid of the difficulties of spiritual struggle. For we have God as a helper, who strengthens us in the difficult path of virtue." + *St. Nektarius of Aegina, The Path to Happiness, 2*

Yes, the angels don't pray for themselves. This is how I pray for people, for the Church and for the body of the Church. The moment you pray for the Church, you are released from your passions. The moment you glorify God, your soul is calmed and sanctified by divine grace. This is the art I want you to learn. God wants us to become like the angels. The angels only glorify God. This is their prayer, glorification of God and nothing else... Doxology is prayer without self-interest. The angels do not pray in order to receive something; they are selfless... When we enter into this prayer, we will glorify God continually, leaving everything to Him, just as our Church

prays 'We commend our whole life to Christ our God.' This is the 'higher mathematics' of our religion! *Saint Porphyrios of Kavsoakalyvia, Wounded by Love*

Be kinder than necessary because everyone is fighting their war or battle and suffering losses.

Live simply, love generously, care deeply for the needs of your neighbour, speak softly... And leave the rest to the Lord.

It is not faith, nor dogmatics, nor mysticism, nor asceticism, nor fasting, nor long prayers, but love that makes one a true Christian.

Everything becomes pointless without this fundamental thing - love for our neighbor. *ST LUKE OF SIMFEROPOL*

Someone who steals ten times a day might decide one day to steal only nine times, and this may be enough for God to enter in and remove from him his sinful ways. God's love is madness indeed, but the madness of God is infinitely wiser than the wisdom of men. *Fr Zacharias of Essex*

You know only his sin... are you going to condemn him for it, and destroy your own soul? And how do you know what tears he has shed about it before God? You may well know about the sin, but you do not know about the repentance. *Abba Dorotheos of Gaza*

I remember once I told Saint Porphyrios, "I'm afraid of what is to come, the ugly times."

He looked at me puzzled and giving me a swift slap on the hand he said, "Who can do you harm, my child, if you have Christ inside your heart?"

Turn your eyes towards Christ. You don't become saints by chasing away the evil. Forget about the evil. You should actually turn your eyes towards Christ and He will save you. Instead of standing at the door and shooing away the enemy, despise him. When you see evil approaching from one direction, you softly give your attention to something else. So, when the evil is coming to offend you, give your interior strength to good, to Christ. Plead: "Our Lord Jesus Christ have mercy on me."

He knows how to give you His mercy and in whatever way that is best for you. And after you are full of good, then you no longer turn your attention towards the evil. With the grace of God, you become good. And then the evil is unable to find a place to stand and disappears!- *St Porphyrios (Bairaktaris)*

INSTRUCTIONS OF SAINT JOHN OF SHANGHAI

1. "We are surrounded by great Providence. There is no "fate" or "blind destiny". There is however the Unsleeping Eye of God's love and our freedom to be in it".

2. "Can you love a person without trusting him? Yes, you can. Truly loving a person does not at all mean deification of all his qualities and admiration for all his actions. True love can notice a person's shortcomings as keenly as anger, and even more. However, unlike malice, love treats human shortcomings in its own, loving way. Love protects and saves the human soul for eternity; malice drowns and kills it. Love loves the person himself; not his sins, not his madness, not his blindness... At the same time, it sees all the imperfections of this world more sharply than malice."

3. "He who is in no hurry to do good will not do it. Good deeds can only be done by the ardent, sincere and burning hearts. Truly kind means speed-of-lightning kind. This lightning speed is an expression of spiritual strength and sacred faith."

"It is a great art to succeed in having your soul sanctified. A person can become a saint anywhere. He can become a saint in Omonia Square, if he wants. At your work, whatever it may be, you can become a saint through meekness, patience, and love. Make a new start every day, with new

resolution, with enthusiasm and love, prayer and silence not with anxiety so that you get a pain in the chest." - SAINT PORPHYRIOS

"God is love. He is not a simple spectator in our lives. He provides and cares like the Father that He is, but He also respects our freedom. He does not pressure us. We should have our hope in God's providence and, since we believe that God is watching over us, we should take courage and throw ourselves into His love and then we will see Him constantly beside us. We will not be afraid that we will make a false step" - St Porphyrios -

"If one has the spirit of sacrifice, then he receives divine assistance and God provides for him. The help one receives from God is analogous to the sacrifice and prayer he does for his fellow human beings" - St Paisios of Mount Athos -

TAKING SURPLUS FOR GRANTED. By St Paisios of Mt Athos

Elder Paisios recalls: "In the cell of Saint Episteme in Sinai, where I used to live, there was very little water. Not far from the cell, water was dripping slowly through a crevice in a rock. I fitted a small vessel, and I could collect up to three litres of water each day. When I came for the water, I put under the crevice an iron tin and read the Akathist to the Holy Theotokos while it was filling up.

I put some water on my head – just the forehead, as one doctor had recommended, took some water to drink, and filled a small jar for the mice and birds that were living in my cell. I also used the water from the cave to wash my clothes and for other such needs. What great joy I felt to have this small amount of water, and how grateful I was to have it! I praised the Lord for the water that I had.

With Pain and love for Contemporary man. Excerpts from the teaching of St Paisios of Mt Athos

People are suffering; they feel lost, but are forced to live in this hellish world. Especially these days, most of them feel that they have been abandoned and that no one cares for them. They have nothing to hold on to. They try to latch onto anything they can find - like a drowning man grabbing onto a straw, hoping that it will keep him afloat. You see, the boat is sinking and people are trying to hold on to the mast, not realizing that the mast too will sink. So, they grab it and they go down even faster. All I am saying is that people are looking for something to hold on to. But as long as they don't hold on to Faith, as long as they do not trust God but rely instead on themselves, there will be no end to their suffering. There is nothing more important than putting one's total trust in God. Pg 30

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Even though ours are difficult and dangerous times, Christ will triumph in the end. You will see many people who realize the value of the Church and understand that without the Church there is no way out. But we must

Why was God born among us?

Why was God born among us? St. Gregory of Nyssa answers that question for us:

"Our nature was sick and needed a doctor. Man had fallen and needed someone to raise him up. He who had stopped doing good needed someone to bring him back to it. He who was closed in darkness needed the presence of life. The prisoner was looking for someone to ransom him, the captive for someone to set him free!"

Later, when I came to the Holy Mount and settled for a short time in the Iberian Skete, I forgot about the scarcity – water was abundant there, for the skete stood on the sunny side. The water was overflowing from a tank that stood nearby. I revelled in the abundance. I washed my hair and feet in it and soon forgot about my life in Sinai. There, I used to cry with gratefulness for the drops of water that I could have, while here in the skete, I forgot all about it because of the surplus. So I left my cell and settled further away, where a tiny water tank stood some eighty metres down the lane.

How confused and how oblivious can we all become in abundance!"

My comment (FrSeraphim) TAKING SURPLUS FOR GRANTED, when exactly enough is not enough.

be true Christians; we must also do our part. Even politicians now understand, given the madness that surround us, that only people of the Church can help. Do not be surprised that they have thrown up their hands in desperation! Some folks came to see me in my Kalyvi and said, "Monks must become missionaries in the world, it's the only solution." These are hard times! If only you could realize the condition we are in and see what is yet to come! Pg 30

-It's one of the signs of our times, that people are seeking help from a poor man like me. I am no good, and I wonder what people find in me, why they come to see me. (I am nothing more than a dry gourd that looks like a watermelon. Today people eat a dry gourd and think it is a watermelon, because from the outside they look similar. They travel from afar without even being sure that they will find me here. I am disgusted with myself; but for them, I feel so much pain. Look at what has happened to our world; and what is becoming of us! The Prophet Isaiah says that a time will come when people will find a man who is wearing only one piece of clothing, and they will say to him, "Come, let us make you our king." (Cf Isa 3:6) May God have pity on us! Pg 31

I constantly pray to God to reveal true human beings, real Christians, to us, and to give them a long life in order to help the people of this world. We should all pray to God to shed His light and bring forth new Christians, young people with pure hearts, like the Maccabees, because this present generation is destroying the world. Pg 32

[NOTE FROM FR SERAPHIM: TAKE THE SAINT'S ADVICE AND ADD THIS TO YOUR PRAYERS!]

- Geronda, why does Saint Cyril of Jerusalem say that the martyrs of the last days will surpass all previous martyrs?"

- Because in the old days we had men of great stature. Our present age is lacking in examples speaking about the Church and monasticism as a whole. Today, there are more words and books and fewer living examples. We admire the holy athletes of our Church, but we do not understand how

much they struggled. We are not able to appreciate their pain, not able to love and strive with philotimo to imitate them, because we have never struggled like they did. Surely the Good God will take into account the age and conditions in which we live, and on that basis He will judge us; with only a slight effort, the crowns we earn will surpass those of our ancestors.
Pg 33

The Faithful Husband That Would Not Abandon His Unfaithful Wife by Elder Joseph of Vatopedi

I will tell you of another characteristic of a proper spouse, which is extremely difficult to find in our day. But we did encounter one such person.

He was in every way a perfect character, a Christian, and completely social. He married late, around thirty years old, not because he was averse to marriage, but because he thought that was how it should be. So he said his prayers with faith, and found himself a young girl and married her. The girl was young, ten years younger than him. Soon after he married her, she began her mischief. He pretended not to notice; he regarded her as his daughter and himself as her father. However, they had important business interests overseas and they had to go there, even if only temporarily. So he took her and they went abroad. When they arrived, she became very obstinate, and would say to herself: "He did this on purpose, to estrange me from my environment. I will desert him." So she abandoned and left him. She came back to Greece, and where do you think she went? To one of those "casino" places, and began to live the life of a free woman — one who is paid.

The husband however, from the day that she left him, never stopped praying with tears and insisting, in fact exhorting God: "All Good One, I will not retreat, I will not leave You alone; You were the One who gave me my

wife. 'By the Lord is a man and woman harmonized' (according to the Bible). I want my wife. If the young girl has been deceived, must she be lost? Why did You come down to earth? Didn't You come to find the lost ones, to heal the sick, to resurrect the dead? I will not retreat. I will not let You rest. I want my wife; bring her back to me. " He wept for two whole years.

His prayer was eventually heard and the young woman came to her senses. "Oh my," she confessed, "God will have to create another Hell, because this one is too small for me!" So she sat down and wrote him a letter, saying: "I dare not address your name; I have no such right. If I return, will you accept me as your servant?" He replied: "My love, why did you mention that word and hurt my feelings? Wasn't it me who sent you on a vacation and I was longing for my love to return to my open arms?"

So, he went and waited for her at the airport, as they had arranged. When she arrived, she fell down and began to beat herself and cry. He took her in his arms. "My love, why are you like this and hurt my feelings? I was longing to see you again. Let's go home now; we never parted — I was always with you." And this young girl proved herself to be a faithful wife from then on.

And that is the stance that a man — a husband — should take.

A Good Person Sees Only Good in Everything

[Elder Daniel of Katounakia](#)

Elder Daniel of Katounakia talks about Elder Philaret, the great hermit of the rocky Karoulia region.

Shoes as a means of humility

I read the following in the "Lavsaik" of Palladius about the life of St. Horus: "At first, living in the desert, he ate herbs and sweet roots, drank water when he was able to find it, and spent all his time in prayer and chanting". I think this is a fully suitable description of the ascetic life of Fr. Philaret. He, as one of the fragrant flowers growing on the rocks of [Karoulia](#), was a true friend of virtue.

He always walked barefoot; and once, our elder, Fr. Gerontius, desiring to test whether his love and simplicity were from God and not egotism, said to him:

"Fr. Philaret..."

"Bless, geronda!"

"You're a hypocrite! You walk around barefoot in an old ryasa, putting your [humility](#) on display!"

"Geronda," answered Fr. Philaret, humbly lowering his gaze, "yes, I'm a hypocrite! What do I have to do to rid myself of this infirmity?"

"Starting from today, walk around in shoes!"

"Alright, geronda. May it be blessed!"

Having bowed low before him, Fr. Philaret left. He found an old pair of shoes somewhere, and, carrying them in his arms, returned to his hesychasterion. He put them on before entering. It was exceedingly painful. After so many years of walking barefoot, his feet, accustomed to freedom, simply could not bear to be fit into a pair of shoes. But obedience and humility, as you know, work miracles! The presence of virtue becomes

evident when your fellow brother controls you, and you humbly submit. Such behavior is a scorching flame for the devil!

"All is well now! Now you're a real humble monk," said geronda.

"May it be blessed, geronda, may it be blessed!" answered Fr. Philaret.

Having made a prostration, he went on his way, stumbling and walking gingerly, like a little child...

Next to the hesychasterion grew a large number of wild herbs. Fr. Philaret would pick the ones that were edible and, bringing them to us, would say: "Eat, fathers. This is from God. These herbs should be eaten by those who labor for the Lord's sake rather than by a slacker like me!"

"I can't swear!"

Once a man wearing a ryasa came to him and called himself a deacon. Seeing the elder's old books, he set his eye on them and, before leaving, took them in secret. He didn't know that at Daphne, before leaving the Holy Mountain, there was a customs inspection checking all the things you were departing with. He got arrested there!

"Where'd you get these books from?" they asked him.

"I got them from... Fr. Philaret at Karoulia, he sold them to me!" lied the deacon in order to justify himself, and continued slandering: "He's illegally selling ancient books!"

The police arrived at the hesychasterion and carried out an investigation. Having believed the miscreant deacon, they filed a case against Fr. Philaret, a holy ascetic. Soon a subpoena came. Most of the fathers don't know what that is; such worldly procedures are unknown to them. We explained what this meant to him, and he said, "But how do I get there? Please take me there."

We did everything that was necessary. We found some clothes that were a bit newer, because his ryasa was just too old and worn out. We also

asked an attorney we were acquainted with to go to court with Fr. Philaret in order to help him, and gathered some money so that father could get to Thessaloniki and stand trial—he whom even the Lord, in our humble opinion, will not condemn “in that day” (Mt. 7:22). He was a heavenly man, a fragrant flower of the desert!

Fr. Philaret said, “I’ll obey the government and go so they can judge me.” And then he went off for Thessaloniki. He hadn’t left the Holy Mountain for a whole 58 years! For 58 years he lived in Karoulia, living off of the wild herbs and water that were given by God there. A blessed man, who had attained a high degree of virtue, was now in court as a defendant. I don’t know how things work there. I’ve never crossed the doorstep of that institution. I only remember what the elder himself told us. He was summoned by the chairman of the court:

“Monk Philaret?”

“Yes, it is I, the unworthy one,” replied Philaret humbly, bowing his head.

“Why did you sell those books?”

“I didn’t sell them! A certain brother came to me and took them in order to read them. He would have returned them later. That’s what I thought...”

“Father, you have to give a sworn testimony in order to be believed. That’s the order of the court procedure”.

“I can’t! In the Gospel it says: *Swear not at all* (Mt. 5:34).”

“But you have to swear, father.”

“How is that done?”

“You have to put your hand on the Gospel.”

Then, Fr. Philaret did three full prostrations and reverently kissed the Gospel...

“Is that enough?”

“No, father; you have to place your hand on the Gospel and say: ‘I swear, etc.’”

“I can’t swear!”

“But if you don’t swear, then you’ll go to prison for nine months!”

“And a thousand times do I agree to go to prison! I await eternal judgment from the Lord for my sins! Am I to be concerned over some nine months in prison?!”

The pseudo-deacon was also present in court. Dressed in an expensive ryasa, he held himself in an important and haughty manner. The attorney he hired told a whole bunch of lies. In particular he said: “Is it possible, Mr. Judge, that this wonderful clergyman would steal books from such a ragamuffin?”

In the end, slander and concealment of the truth inclined the judge to the side of the dazzling thief, and the monk-ascetic, appearing before them in an old cassock, unskilled in the art of lying, who had never uttered an oath before, was found guilty. The verdict was pronounced and the police took Fr. Philaret to prison.

The judges didn’t care what would happen to the monk, but the ordinary folk did. They collected the necessary amount of money to pay bail and have the elder released from prison. Fr. Philaret with his usual simplicity, having thanked everyone, went back on his way to Karoulia—the place of his many years of solitude. He thanked us, who had given him all the help we could, too. “Thank you, fathers,” he told us. “Pray that the Lord may also deliver me from eternal prison!”

By the way, he was also very pleased with our attorney, who had defended him in court. This holy hermit always thought kindly of everyone. He told us enthusiastically:

“The Spirit of God abides in that attorney! He described everything exactly the way it happened!”

“Geronda,” I told him, “that’s simply his job!”

“No,” insisted the elder, “he has the Spirit of God!”

I asked him:

“Geronda, you’ve lived away from the world for 58 years. What was it like to be there now?”

A good person, as we have already said, sees only good in everything. He answered: “What can I say, fathers? All the people out there, in the world, are very good. They’re all running around, to and fro, for the sake of their salvation; all of them but me, a lazy sinner, sitting around in these rocky cliffs and not doing any work, not fulfilling the will of God!”

Having said that, he retired to his cell, glorifying God for sending him such a trial towards the end of his life for the salvation of his soul.

A blessed repose

Once, when he was a very old man, he invited me and Fr. Akaky to his cell and with joy said:

“May you be well, my children. It’s good that you came, because I won’t be seeing you again! I’m leaving tonight... But before that happens, I’d like you to console me.”

“How, geronda?”

“Read the [Psalter](#) for me; something calming for the soul.”

We read a number of different psalms, and tears of joy ran down geronda’s cheeks, and the whole time he kept making the sign of the cross. After we finished, he said:

“And I’d like to ask of you one last thing: chant for me the hymn of the Theotokos, ‘It is truly meet’. But let’s do it while standing up, like we do when we sing the national anthem of our homeland!”

He got up with difficulty. He was very exhausted and his skin had become almost transparent in color. After we finished, the elder, with tears of joy in his eyes, hugging and kissing us, said: “My children, I’m seeing you here for the last time! Forgive me, forgive me!”

Everyone cried. Fr. Philaret was calming us down. We left deeply moved. In the morning we were informed that he had passed away! Just as he had predicted...

We buried him among the rocks in a befitting and worthy manner. In layman’s words, I’ll put it this way: a star of monastic asceticism went out on the sky of Mt. Athos, but left behind it a bright trail, showing us how to struggle and remain consistent in ascetical labor. May his memory be eternal! Pray for me, father!

It often happens that towards the end of our lives the All-Holy God sends us some kind of trial that makes us better, and those around us also benefit from it. So it was with Fr. Philaret, who labored with humility and was rewarded by God. You have heard, Mr. Melinos, how the devil attempted to perturb a man of virtue and ascetic labor; but the All-Holy God protected him with His grace, and the soul of the ascetic received no harm, but was strengthened in its love for the Lord. This love became more and more inflamed, and with increasing zeal the elder praised God.

[Elder Daniel of Katounakia](#) Translated by Feodor Nemets
[Monastery.ru](#) 10/24/2019
<https://orthochristian.com/124920.html>

Priest Daniel Sysoev

(Nov 19) On this day in 2009, an Orthodox priest, Priest Daniel Sysoev, was martyred for preaching Christ to Muslims and converting them. An angry Muslim entered this priest's church with a gun, and shouted "Where is the priest Daniel?"

People ran out. Fr Daniel was behind the icon-screen in the altar, and could easily have escaped out the side door through the vestry. Instead, he stepped out from the altar into the nave of the church and said, "I am Daniel." And he was shot to death in cold blood in the middle of the Church.

Fr Daniel, on the day of his martyrdom, had not yet reached his 35th birthday. He was born in the Soviet Union, and lived the first 17 years of his life behind the Iron Curtain. He loved Christ from his youth, even in officially atheist Soviet Russia, and, even though as a child and young man he was mocked by his peers and school teachers for his faith in Jesus Christ, he never abandoned his saviour.

And at the age of 34, he was granted a martyr's death for the preaching of the Gospel. This isn't a story from centuries ago, although Fr Daniel is now numbered among those in heaven who died for the faith from the earliest years of the Church.

Glory to God who is wondrous in His saints

Questions and answers

Are you born again?

Do you understand John chapter 3? I am born from above, of water and the spirit, and after I went into the font, I came out a new creature. Therefore, despite my sins, and there are so many, I am a temple of the Holy Spirit, and unworthy son of the church. I have a question for you. What is salvation? Another way of asking this question is: "What is the purpose of your life, and how does the incarnation of the son of God facilitate this purpose?" Priest Seraphim Holland <https://youtu.be/rIBk0xH-5ac>

Now, you HAVE A JOB TO DO! Answer All the questions, above (there are 5). Send the answers to Fr David or Fr Seraphim. "Do it! Do it now!" (That last phrase is something my grandson Noah would say when he was two years old and wanted something right away)

Would God forgive suicide when used to escape the mark of the beast?

Suicide is not a solution for avoiding the mark of the beast. Suicide is plain and simple a terrible sin. If it were to avoid the mark of the beast it would be an act of cowardice. You protect your family by praying with your blood. Do more prostrations, pray the Jesus prayer, Pray the psalter. Increase your intercessions for everybody you know and even people you don't know in groups such as for instance those who have been vxd or those who are under great economic stress. If a person is not fasting or going to every service they're able to go to then they are a fool if they think that they can endure when things become really terrible. Living life like we usually do and hoping that problems go away is not the solution.

A Word from Fr Seraphim

Speaking the Truth

If you speak the truth, there are always people that will not like it, including Bishops and Priests, and politicians, neighbors and friends and enemies. It doesn't matter if you're a man or a woman, a priest or Bishop. It doesn't matter if you're in the free world (which is not free) or in prison. It does not matter if speaking the truth can cause you problems.

Keep on speaking the truth but even more important than speaking the truth, live the truth, and do your prostrations. Do many prostrations every day, including for those who are insane and possibly even demon-possessed. If you are not doing prostrations, then why are you wasting your life? If you cannot do prostrations, you can do something!

INTENSITY!

You must pray with intensity! Saying your prayers sometimes, or rattling through them, or saying them with very little attention is not enough. The temptations in this world are intense. The devil is roaming around like a roaring lion seeking to see whom he can devour. If you do not pray with intensity, you will be lost. Time rolls on, and eventually, it ends. What will you be at the end of your life? There won't be any excuses left for how you spend your time.

Liars and thieves and servants of Satan are everywhere and are even living in our church, you know. I'm certain that some are provocateurs for the evil one in the Orthodox Church. It's always been that way! Read The Acts of the Apostles and the letters of Saint Paul! We should not be afraid of this. There are always evil people. How do you fight with evil people? Certainly not by cynicism! Certainly not by fear! You fight evil people with good, and you become good by living with intensity.

Speaking against evil people and presenting the truth whenever people say lies and politics and all the rest is marginally useful. The best thing you and I can do is live a Christian Life, do not compromise, and do our prostrations and pray for the world. Always live the spiritual life with intensity!

One of the biggest temptations in prison is that it is easy to live without intensity. Sure, there can be fear and anxiety about various things, but that's not intensity; that's just a human reaction to our environment. It is very easy to go from day-to-day and be part of the droning of the routine of

the prison. If you allow yourself to be part of that hypnotic life, you cannot consider yourself to be a Christian. And in the free world, which is full of people who are not free, the same hypnotic life exists. There is less of a rigid schedule, but most allow themselves to be rigidly manipulated by phones and media and entertainment and the mistaken idea that we have to work overtime on our jobs, and there is no time to go to church because of our weekend responsibilities and a thousand other things.

Those who are part of the hypnotic life of the world, whether it's in prison or in the so-called free world, take on the opinions of that world. This will always happen. We must actively fight to be intense! Then we can see the world's lies for what they are - the way of death.

If you are receiving this newsletter, it is likely that you are an Orthodox Christian or inquiring into our beautiful faith. What is it that you want out of the Orthodox faith? What is it that Fr David and Fr Seraphim are trying to teach you? We are not interested in you learning a bunch of "Orthodox" things. We are interested in you learning and following the way of life.

People often ask me, and maybe they will ask you, "what is the difference between Orthodoxy" and, say, "being a Baptist." There are many ways to answer this question, but the best one, in my opinion, is that Orthodoxy is the way of life and it is intense and is our whole life, and there is no part of our life that is not part of it. It is to be joined with Christ so that we can become perfected as we were made to be. This answer will offend many people who are not Orthodox, and it will offend the mainstream Orthodox. It is still a true answer.

Christianity is a battle in the arena, to the death. Either our sins will die, and God will reign in our hearts, or our sins will kill us, and we will be without God. There is no in-between. There is no time for comfort and consoling ourselves by taking our ease. Does this statement frighten you? Do you feel you can't meet this mark? Good! Nobody can meet this mark with the grace of God! We can struggle to the best of our abilities, and God will help us. But, if we take our ease and are lazy, the grace of God is not with us, or the better way to put this is because God is everywhere, is that the grace of God is not energized in us.

Orthodox Christianity is only concerned with the perfection of the human soul, and this is an arduous and difficult process. Take stock of this faith, and don't listen to the lies of the world regarding Christianity.

Christianity is nothing less than a spiritual way of life that leads to perfection. Since we are so far from perfection, it makes sense that it is a

difficult way of life and that we must apply ourselves to it with our entire heart. Priest Seraphim Holland

“Do Everything As I Do”: On the Only Homily Geronda Gregory of Dochariou Ever Gave

Today marks one year since the departure to the Lord of Elder Gregory (Zumis), abbot of the Athonite Dochariou Monastery. The more the days pass, the brighter the image of the Elder emerges in the memories of those who passed through his school. We offer the story of a man who prefers to simply be known as Μαθητής (Mathetes).

Elder Gregory and Fr. Isidore

The first time I was in Dochariou, my spiritual father took me. The monastery wasn't restored yet and was illuminated by kerosene lamps; and despite his many serious illnesses, Elder Gregory was full of strength. Every morning before obediences, the Elder gathered the pilgrims in the guest house and spoke with them for about an hour. I would like to describe one of these conversations, which revealed to me the theology of our Elder.

This morning, two young monks, theology students, came to the guest house. When the opportunity arose, they started to ask the Elder questions through Fr. Makarios who would translate. The conversation was full of academic terminology, and now I can't even remember the contents of the talk.

But Fr. Gregory unexpectedly said to them: “You are adulterers and therefore cannot become priests.”

Fr. Charalampios of Dochariou Monastery There was an awkward pause, but after a while the fathers tried to explain to the Elder that they had committed mortal sins under the influence of the antichrist ideology that had reigned in their country for a long time, for which they had repented and even received the tonsure.

Having heard them out, the Elder replied: “A priest preaches only one sermon his entire life: ‘Do everything as I do.’ But I see the mold planted in you by satan, and therefore, you can never say these words.”

But the fathers did not agree with the Elder and tried to tell him about the difficult situation in the post-soviet space, about the lack of clergy for the churches that were being reborn. The Elder quickly stood up, grabbed his staff, and leaving the guest house, said: “You are like those who purchase fiery Gehenna with their own gold.”

On the slopes surrounding Dochariou, there are about 3,000 olive trees, so the fathers and the other pilgrims and I spent two weeks on our knees gathering the olives, and at night we went to the Divine services. Of course it was difficult, but the sight of how the elderly fathers and even old Fr. Charalampos worked on par with me, after standing all night in the stasidia, added strength to my fight with inner protests.

I remember my first day gathering olives. Fr. Seraphim hadn't even managed to explain to me the specifics of this work, which was new to me, when I received a stick upside the head from the Elder.

Geronda was indignant: “It all begins with conversations, turns into friendship, and ends with a complete breakdown of the monastic life.”

My idealistic view of life in the Athonite monastery—one of dignity, peace and mutual friendship—faded away like smoke over my two weeks of obediences.

But a real temptation for me was daily communication with the Elder. Every morning, up to fifty pilgrims would gather in the guest house for conversations with Geronda Gregory, and every day, several of them would leave red-faced with shame. Every morning, I was as if transported to apostolic times, when the Church was filled with those speaking in tongues and prophesying. It's uncomfortable for me to write here about what I saw and heard, although it all happened in front of a multitude of witnesses—it's not a secret confession. The realization that the darkness of my soul had lost its impenetrability became a serious test for my psyche.

My spiritual father always repeats that solid spiritual food is not for everyone, and that neophytes should start with milk. Two weeks later, my spiritual father and I, despite the offer to make a real monk out of me and the violent storm going on, ordered a small motor boat and set off for Ouranoupolis. My spiritual father flew to his native Donskoy Monastery in Moscow, to clean the periodically-clogged sewer, and I went to study in Europe.

Perhaps remembering my crushing defeat during my first visit to Dochariou, my spiritual father fed me milk, explaining that I was unnecessarily embarrassed by the troubles that befell me and by human rebellions.

“The evil one paints pictures of well-being in your heart, but the path of every Christian leads to Golgotha,” he said.

And when I asked him one time how I could know that the Lord hears my prayers, he answered: “When your heart weeps, Christ hears you.”

I tried to hold these words in my heart for several years, and they interpreted this homily of Elder Gregory for me.

Returning to the monastery barely alive, the Elder himself went out to do construction a few days later

After graduating, with the blessing of my spiritual father, I went to Dochariou again. The reconstruction in the monastery was in full swing, and our Elder's health was really faltering. Both his kidneys had failed and he was in the hospital. When they brought him to the monastery in 2012, the old monks wept at how he looked. But every time he returned from the hospital after another complication, within a few days the Elder would rise up like a phoenix to continue his only sermon:

“Do everything as I do.”

He preached the Crucified Christ to us every minute. Geronda couldn't see very well and had serious pain in his legs, but leaning on his staff, he could stand through an entire night service, and then in the afternoon, having barely reached us where we were pouring concrete, with two staves in hand, he would stand in the cement dust until evening. How many times I plopped down in the stasidia, exhausted then after lifting up my eyes and seeing the Elder standing in the altar, I would get up with shame. Ascending Golgotha, Geronda himself pulled all the brethren along behind him, and I don't recall a single one he neglected.

The Elder was a man who crushed our hearts and taught them to weep for twenty hours a day. Concrete work in Dochariou was true servitude, from sunrise to sunset, running under the constant cry of the Elder. Four hours of sleep, leg cramps, services until morning, trapeza with icy spring water, and again—wheelbarrows with concrete or heavy rocks, and hearts pounding from the grueling labor. Work on feast days, work on Sundays... Geronda, turning from an infirm old man into a frenzied pirate, humbling both the laborer and the monastery's father-confessor alike, but all the while boldly promising:

“The Lord will have mercy upon you for your crippled hands.”

It was very hard physically, but even harder morally—not to be offended by the person humbling you. But, having seen real life examples of fathers who made the Elder give up on them and were then carried away by demons into the dark abyss, I would go to Fr. Gregory's cell every evening and take his blessing. When I told Geronda in confession that I was only able to overcome all my resentments against him by evening, he answered, “If you don't manage to forgive someone everything within five minutes, then you're demon-possessed.”

Once, after obediences, Fr. Sisoës asked me to help him with some stone masonry. Two other fathers also came—Ephraim and Isidore. We worked at night, and not fearing the Elder, we spoke with Fr. Isidore, comparing the works of Archimandrite Sophrony (Sakharov) with the Gospel. At three in the morning, we went to church straight from our obedience, and after the service—to the trapeza.

During trapeza, the Elder said: “Orthodoxy knows neither Sophronology nor Paisiology, nor Porphyrology, but I want to remind you about the Samaritan Woman, whom the wisdom of the prophets enabled to see Christ. Read the Sacred Scriptures.”

Geronda’s theology was pure and sober. For example, he was very cautious about the wide distribution of ascetic literature. Himself being a true ascetic and man of prayer, and having the venerable Philotheos and Amphilochios as his teachers, he would warn about the danger of concentrating one’s attention only on acquiring the habit and fruits of prayer. The Elder told us that the *podvig* of prayer must begin with the crushing of our hearts of stone that are overflowing with passions, so that at the end of our lives, despite acquiring the habit of prayer, we won’t suffer a catastrophe the consequences of which cannot be eliminated in the little time we have left.

Indeed, Dochariou is markedly different from the other Athonite monasteries and sketes—and not only by the laborious obediences. You don’t see workers and monks walking around saying the Jesus Prayer orally, and it’s even difficult to find a monk with a prayer rope outside his cell.

Fr. Amphilochios of Dochariou Monastery I spoke with Geronda about prayer three times. The first time was when an elderly monk approached me during a service and said: “How can you pray and not listen to this delightful Byzantine chant?”

I asked Fr. Martirius, a translator, to go see the Elder with me. To my question of whether we should pray during the services, Geronda answered that we must pray always and everywhere; if you want to do prostrations, don’t be embarrassed and don’t be shy—it’s the same if you are streaming tears.

The second time I spoke with Geronda about prayer was when I received a text message on a cell phone I had concealed from the Elder... The message upset me so much that I couldn’t do anything right for several days. When Fr. Martirius translated for the Elder what happened, he began to groan: “Oi yoi yoi, how could you?! Look, I have numerous spiritual children on the mainland, and I can’t leave them without help, but every time I talk with them on the phone (the Elder had a landline phone in his cell), prayer leaves me.”

And the third time, the Elder himself came and chastised me (I had thrown some half-eaten noodles in the garbage): “You did a very bad thing for your prayer.”

The Elder again returned to what happened in the morning at trapeza: “We needn’t peep through the keyhole to see if someone is praying. He who has prayer loves everyone around himself, every plant, every rock and noodle; he would never throw it in the sop!”

A few months later, the monastery doctor, Fr. Ephraim, again reminded me of what happened, but in this way: “You remember what the Elder said about noodles? He said it about me.”

Geronda Gregory at the construction site The Elder would be transformed while serving the Liturgy: Before you stood a defenseless child, chalice in hand—such a sermon of meekness is impossible to fake. When I managed to stand in the stasidia behind the abbot’s seat instead of Fr. Ioannicius during the services, I always smelled the sweet fragrance emanating from Geronda. The first time was after I communed, and I turned away from the chalice, as we do in our churches, and went to wash it down with blessed water. Only a month later did the Elder come up to me at the construction site and quietly whisper: “After Communion, we don’t turn our backs on Christ.”

For many on the Holy Mountain and beyond, the Elder was a temptation and a stumbling block. The hermits who passed through Dochariou were tempted by the backbreaking labor that prevented them from praying; the zealots and patriots were tempted by the Elder’s refusal to “climb onto the barricades” for the purity of the Church; the monasteries were tempted by the Elder’s statements about how the money of the British royal family is disastrous for Athos; the Prime Minister of Greece and the British Prince, whom Geronda didn’t allow into his Dochariou, were probably tempted; the Patriarch of Constantinople was tempted when he asked, “Why did the Elder recruit these Russians,” and the Elder got up and left, saying on the way out, “How can I not receive those whom the Theotokos sent?” and despite the ban from the Patriarch, not long before his repose he tonsured his last Russian monk—Fr. Kirinos.

Our Geronda was a good tree, bearing good fruit. I remember the inhabitants of Dochariou...

Fr. Amphilochios is the brethren’s confessor, who’s been with the Elder since childhood. He is a true preacher of humility, whose prayers work miracles. When you look at Fr. Amphilochios, passing through the church, crossing himself and venerating the icons, you immediately realize how proudly you walked and crossed yourself in church and venerated the icons with a sense of personal dignity all this time. So many times I asked him questions and received the same answer: “What can I know? My Elder is still alive.”¹

And every time he had the need, he would run up the mountain to the monastery, to ask his geronda about this or that.

Fr. Chariton from Dochariou Fr. Chariton is an ascetic and man of prayer. I remember, about ten years ago, a friend of mine who is an atheist, the vice dean of a European university, decided to get another grant to work on Mt. Athos. For the first time in his life, he went into the Orthodox Church of the Holy Angels in Dochariou and stood in the stasidia. Fr. Chariton was serving that day. He was censuring the church, and when he reached the stasidia this researcher was standing in, the latter broke down and began to cry. Fr. Chariton was a living homily on humility and repentance, the existence of which my European educated companion didn’t even suspect. He was later baptized in Dochariou and even lived there for a while.

There was Fr. Theologos, of whom it could be said: “Here is a Greek, in whom there is no guile” (cf. Jn. 1:47). When he would sing at the services after heavy obediences, it was he who sang most soberly on the Holy Mountain.

I’m not worried about harming the brethren with my praise, writing about them this way—they, like their elder, don’t surf the internet.

When the end of my time for defending my doctorate was drawing near, I went to Geronda and asked his blessing to go to the school, but the Elder answered: “Stay in the monastery. Here at the construction site, with a wheelbarrow in your hands, you’ll write your doctorate and the Lord will give you a grade.”

But a while later, he asked me to order a chandelier from the Bohemian factory for the Dochariou wonderworking icon of the Mother of God, “She Who is Quick to Hear,” and I went to the university. A week later I began to help at the construction site—so much so that at night I would sit down to drink some tea, and in the morning I would open my eyes to find cold tea in my hand. I didn’t go back to the university. I defended my dissertation with a wheelbarrow in my hands, as my Elder said, and it couldn’t be otherwise.

The Dochariou we knew was our Elder. I believe that he, just like before, will defend his monastery and not leave any of us without his help.

Source: <https://orthochristian.com/124860.html>

1 Fr. Amphilochios was chosen to replace Elder Gregory as abbot. See: <http://orthochristian.com/117716.html>. —Trans.

Prepared by Olga Orlova Translated by Jesse Dominick 10/22/2019

Answers to: Questions about the Genealogy of Christ (Mat 1:1-17)

ANSWER 1. "Of which then is it necessary to speak first? How the Virgin is of David. How then shall we know that she is of David? Harken unto God, telling Gabriel to go unto "a virgin betrothed to a man (whose name was Joseph), of the house and lineage of David." What now wouldst thou have plainer than this, when thou hast heard that the Virgin was of the house and lineage of David?"

"Now that the Virgin was of the race of David is indeed from these things evident; but wherefore he gave not her genealogy, but Joseph's, requires explanation. For what cause was it then? It was not the law among the Jews that the genealogy of women should be traced. In order then that he might keep the custom, and not seem to be making alterations from the beginning, and yet might make the Virgin known to us, for this cause he hath passed over her ancestors in silence, and traced the genealogy of Joseph. For if he had done this with respect to the Virgin, he would have seemed to be introducing novelties; and if he had passed over Joseph in silence, we should not have known the Virgin's forefathers. In order, therefore that we might learn, touching Mary, who she was, and of what origin, and that the laws might remain undisturbed, he hath traced the genealogy of her espoused husband, and shown him to be of the house of David. For when this hath been clearly proved, that other fact is demonstrated with it, namely, that the Virgin likewise is sprung from thence, by reason that this righteous man, even as I have already said, would not have endured to take a wife from another race." (Chrysostom - Homilies on Matthew, Homily 2)

ANSWER 2. Sarah was the mother of Isaac. He is so named because Abraham and Sarah both initially disbelieved when they heard that she would bear a child, and laughed. Isaac means laughter. Sarah was great in years, and had been barren, and according to all worldly wisdom, having a child was impossible. This is why she laughed.

"And when Abram was ninety years old and nine, the LORD appeared to Abram and said unto him, I am the Almighty God; walk before me, and be thou perfect. And I will make my covenant between me and thee, and will multiply thee exceedingly." (Gen. 17:1-2)

"And God said unto Abraham, As for Sarai, thy wife, thou shalt not call her name Sarai, but Sarah shall her name be. {16} And I will bless her, and give thee a son also of her: yea, I will bless her, and she shall be a mother of nations; kings of people shall be of her. {17} Then Abraham fell upon his face, and laughed, and said in his heart, Shall a child be born unto him that is an hundred years old? And shall Sarah, that is ninety years old, bear? " (Gen. 17:15-17)

Later, when the three angels appeared to Abraham, it was Sarah's turn to laugh.

"And they said unto him, Where is Sarah thy wife? And he said, Behold, in the tent. {10} And he said, I will certainly return unto thee according to the time of life; and, lo, Sarah thy wife shall have a son. And Sarah heard it in the tent door, which was behind him. {11} Now Abraham and Sarah were old and well stricken in age, and it ceased to be with Sarah after the manner of women. {12} Therefore, Sarah laughed within herself, saying, After I am waxed old shall I have pleasure, my lord being old also? {13} And the LORD said unto Abraham, Wherefore did Sarah laugh, saying, Shall I of a surety bear a child, which am old? {14} Is anything too hard for the LORD? At the time appointed, I will return unto thee, according to the time of life, and Sarah shall have a son. {15} Then Sarah denied, saying, I laughed not, for she was afraid. And he said, Nay, but thou didst laugh. " (Gen. 18:9-15)

If God has raised a great nation out of barrenness, is this not a sign to us, that he will raise our barren souls up to the knowledge of Himself? This story is not merely a quaint tale but a spiritual reality. We can indeed be

raised up, and all that is barren in us can become fruitful, if only we truly believe and struggle with ourselves.

ANSWER 3. A "type" is a foreshadowing of something to come. For example, when Moses stuck his staff three times in the bitter waters of Marah, and they became sweet, this was a foreshadowing, or "type," of baptism. The burning bush, which burnt, but was not consumed, was a "type" of the Theotokos, who, being a mortal, bore divinity in her womb and was not consumed. There are hundreds of "types" in the Old Testament.

Isaac is a type of Christ. Remember when Abraham was told to sacrifice Isaac? Since Abraham was to be the father of many nations, so too was Isaac, as his progeny. So too is Christ the "Author and finisher of our faith" (Heb 12:2), and He sacrificed Himself for our sake. Our tradition tells us that Isaac did not resist his father and would have gone willingly to his death if the angel had not intervened.

"And Isaac spake unto Abraham, his father, and said, My father: and he said, Here am I, my son. And he said, Behold the fire and the wood: but where is the lamb for a burnt offering? {8} And Abraham said, My son, God will provide himself a lamb for a burnt offering: so they went both of them together. {9} And they came to the place which God had told him of; and Abraham built an altar there, and laid the wood in order, and bound Isaac his son, and laid him on the altar upon the wood. {10} And Abraham stretched forth his hand, and took the knife to slay his son. {11} And the angel of the LORD called unto him out of heaven, and said, Abraham, Abraham: and he said, Here am I. {12} And he said, Lay not thine hand upon the lad, neither do thou any thing unto him: for now I know that thou fearest God, seeing thou hast not withheld thy son, thine only son from me. {13} And Abraham lifted up his eyes, and looked, and behold behind him a ram caught in a thicket by his horns: and Abraham went and took the ram, and offered him up for a burnt offering in the stead of his son." (Gen. 22:7-13)

ANSWER 4. The mother of Jacob was Rebecca.

Jacob had two wives. They were both daughters of Laban, under whom Jacob worked for seven years to marry the youngest, Rachel, whom he loved. The eldest was Leah. After Jacob did his service, on the wedding day, Laban tricked Jacob by substituting Leah for Rachel. This was possible because of veils! Jacob was allowed to marry Rachel also, after contracting for another seven years of service.

"And Laban had two daughters: the name of the elder was Leah, and the name of the younger was Rachel. {17} Leah was tender-eyed, but Rachel was beautiful and well-favored. {18} And Jacob loved Rachel; and said, I will serve thee seven years for Rachel thy younger daughter. {19} And Laban said, It is better that I give her to thee, than that I should give her to another man: abide with me. {20} And Jacob served seven years for Rachel; and they seemed unto him but a few days, for the love he had to her. {21} And Jacob said unto Laban, Give me my wife, for my days are fulfilled, that I may go in unto her. {22} And Laban gathered together all the men of the place, and made a feast. {23} And it came to pass in the evening, that he took Leah his daughter, and brought her to him; and he went in unto her. {24} And Laban gave unto his daughter Leah Zilpah his maid for an handmaid. {25} And it came to pass, that in the morning, behold, it was Leah: and he said to Laban, What is this thou hast done unto me? did not I serve with thee for Rachel? wherefore then hast thou beguiled me? {26} And Laban said, It must not be so done in our country, to give the younger before the firstborn. {27} Fulfil her week, and we will give thee this also for the service which thou shalt serve with me yet seven other years. {28} And

Jacob did so, and fulfilled her week: and he gave him Rachel his daughter to wife also." (Gen. 29:16-28)

There is a mystical meaning to the two wives of Jacob. Leah had many children, and Rachel was barren for a long while. One must read the full story to see the mystical meaning. St Andrew of Crete, in his Great Canon (read during Great Lent), hymns: "Because of his crying need the Patriarch endured the scorching heat of the day, and he bore the frost of the night, daily making gains, shepherding, struggling, slaving, in order to make 2 wives."

"By the two wives understand action and direct knowledge in contemplation; Leah as action, for she had many children, and Rachel as knowledge, which is obtained by much labor. For without labors, my soul, neither action nor contemplation will achieve success." (The Great Canon of St Andrew for Monday, Ode 4)

ANSWER 5. Leah bore the first many sons of Jacob, including Judah. Altogether, she bore six of the twelve patriarchs.

"And when the LORD saw that Leah was hated, he opened her womb: but Rachel was barren. {32} And Leah conceived, and bare a son, and she called his name Reuben: for she said, Surely the LORD hath looked upon my affliction; now therefore my husband will love me. {33} And she conceived again, and bare a son; and said, Because the LORD hath heard that I was hated, he hath therefore given me this son also: and she called his name Simeon. {34} And she conceived again, and bare a son; and said, Now this time will my husband be joined unto me, because I have born him three sons: therefore was his name called Levi. {35} And she conceived again, and bare a son: and she said, Now will I praise the LORD: therefore she called his name Judah; and left bearing." (Gen. 29:31-35)

The penultimate son of Jacob, and the second youngest brother of Judas, was Joseph.

"And God remembered Rachel, and God hearkened to her, and opened her womb. {23} And she conceived, and bare a son; and said, God hath taken away my reproach: {24} And she called his name Joseph; and said, The LORD shall add to me another son." (Gen. 30:22-24)

ANSWER 6. Judas was the father in law of Thamar. He had a son, Er, who was Thamar's first husband: "And Judah took a wife for Er his firstborn, whose name was Thamar." (Gen. 38:6)

There were no children out of this union, as: "...Er, Judah's firstborn, was wicked in the sight of the LORD; and the LORD slew him." (Gen. 38:7)

Thamar was then married to Onan, whose sin of selfish self-gratification has much to teach us: "And Judah said unto Onan, Go in unto thy brother's wife, and marry her, and raise up seed to thy brother. {38:9} And Onan knew that the seed should not be his; and it came to pass, when he went in unto his brother's wife, that he spilled it on the ground, lest that he should give seed to his brother. {38:10} And the thing which he did displeased the LORD: wherefore he slew him also." (Gen. 38:8-10)

Poor Thamar was now twice a widow, and had not "raised up seed for Israel". Judah told her to wait until his younger son Shelah was grown, and in the meantime, live in his house as a chaste widow: "Then said Judah to Thamar his daughter in law, Remain a widow at thy father's house, till Shelah my son be grown: for he said, Lest peradventure he die also, as his brethren did. And Thamar went and dwelt in her father's house." (Gen. 38:11)

In time, Judah's wife Shuah died. Judah, perhaps not thinking clearly, went away with his shepherds, and did not mate Thamar with his son Shelah, even though he was grown. This arrangement sets the stage for Thamar's deception and sin with Judah. The scripture tells the tale very clearly: "And it was told Thamar, saying, Behold thy father in law goeth up to Timnath to shear his sheep. {14} And she put her widow's garments off from her, and covered her with a veil, and wrapped herself, and sat in an

open place, which is by the way to Timnath; for she saw that Shelah was grown, and she was not given unto him to wife. {15} When Judah saw her, he thought her to be an harlot; because she had covered her face. {16} And he turned unto her by the way, and said, Go to, I pray thee, let me come in unto thee; (for he knew not that she was his daughter in law.) And she said, What wilt thou give me, that thou mayest come in unto me? {17} And he said, I will send thee a kid from the flock. And she said, Wilt thou give me a pledge, till thou send it? {18} And he said, What pledge shall I give thee? And she said, Thy signet, and thy bracelets, and thy staff that is in thine hand. And he gave it her, and came in unto her, and she conceived by him." (Gen. 38:13-18)

Later, Judah became aware that Thamar was pregnant, not knowing that he had lain with her. He hypocritically wanted to punish her, but her craftiness (when she asked for a pledge before her harlotry) saved her, and was very instructive to Judah.

"And it came to pass about three months after, that it was told Judah, saying, Thamar thy daughter in law hath played the harlot; and also, behold, she is with child by whoredom. And Judah said, Bring her forth, and let her be burnt. {25} When she was brought forth, she sent to her father in law, saying, By the man, whose these are, am I with child: and she said, Discern, I pray thee, whose are these, the signet, and bracelets, and staff. {26} And Judah acknowledged them, and said, She hath been more righteous than I; because that I gave her not to Shelah my son. And he knew her again no more." (Gen. 38:24-26)

Marvelous are the works of God. Out of a sinful, incestual union is raised up the Son of God. The blood of harlots and fornicators beats in his heart. He has truly taken on all of our sins, and made everything clean, as even his genealogy shows.

ANSWER 7. Phares and Zara were born of harlotry, described in the question above. Their names are very significant and are descriptive of the birth process, and the economy of God, and the salvation of man.

Zara was the firstborn, means "East" or "brightness." Phares was the second born, although he preceded his brother completely out of the womb, means "division" or "rupture" or "interruption," as Blessed Theofylact has it.

Here is the story of the birth: "And it came to pass in the time of her travail, that, behold, twins were in her womb. {28} And it came to pass, when she travailed, that the one put out his hand: and the midwife took and bound upon his hand a scarlet thread, saying, This came out first. {29} And it came to pass, as he drew back his hand, that, behold, his brother came out: and she said, How hast thou broken forth? This breach be upon thee: therefore his name was called Phares. {30} And afterward came out his brother, that had the scarlet thread upon his hand: and his name was called Zara." (Gen. 38:27-30)

This story has great theological significance. If we were to read the scriptures in isolation, and try to glean meaning with little understanding, we would miss much of the significant meaning in passages such as this. Fortunately, we, who are not holy, have the holy Fathers, who have expressed wondrously the mind of the church, and helped illuminate the sometimes dark sayings of holy writ.

Phares was aptly named, as he interfered with the natural order. The babe who put his hand out of the womb first should have been born first. Zara first showed his hand and then withdrew it, and so to did the life of Christ appear in the holy ones who lived before the circumcision (such men as Adam, and Seth, and Enoch, and Noah, Job, Melchisedec, and the rest). When the law came, this way of life receded. Later, with the coming of Christ, it blossomed forth again, through the blood of Christ, which was prophesied by the scarlet thread.

ANSWER 8. Rachab was a harlot, who dwelt in the pagan land of Canaan, in the city of Jericho. When Joshua, the son of Nun wished to conquer Jericho, he sent spies into the city to gather military intelligence. These spies stayed with Rachab.

"And Joshua the son of Nun sent out of Shittim two men to spy secretly, saying, Go view the land, even Jericho. And they went, and came into an harlot's house, named Rachab, and lodged there." (Josh 2:1)

The king of the city became aware of their incursion, and Rachab put herself at great risk by protecting the men: "And the king of Jericho sent unto Rachab, saying, Bring forth the men that are come to thee, which are entered into thine house: for they be come to search out all the country. {4} And the woman took the two men, and hid them, and said thus, There came men unto me, but I wist not whence they were: {5} And it came to pass about the time of shutting of the gate, when it was dark, that the men went out: whither the men went I wot not: pursue after them quickly; for ye shall overtake them. {6} But she had brought them up to the roof of the house, and hid them with the stalks of flax, which she had laid in order upon the roof." (Josh 2:3-6)

Rachab was a wise woman, who knew of the exploits of the Jews; this knowledge found a fertile place in her heart, and she, a pagan, believed in the true God.

"And she said unto the men, I know that the LORD hath given you the land, and that your terror is fallen upon us, and that all the inhabitants of the land faint because of you. {10} For we have heard how the LORD dried up the water of the Red sea for you, when ye came out of Egypt; and what ye did unto the two kings of the Amorites, that were on the other side Jordan, Sihon and Og, whom ye utterly destroyed. {11} And as soon as we had heard these things, our hearts did melt, neither did there remain any more courage in any man, because of you: for the LORD your God, he is God in heaven above, and in earth beneath." (Josh 2:9-11)

She, therefore, begged mercy of the two men. They covenanted with her to save she and her household: "Now therefore, I pray you, swear unto me by the LORD, since I have showed you kindness, that ye will also show kindness unto my father's house, and give me a true token: {13} And that ye will save alive my father, and my mother, and my brethren, and my sisters, and all that they have, and deliver our lives from death. {14} And the men answered her, Our life for yours, if ye utter not this our business. And it shall be, when the LORD hath given us the land, that we will deal kindly and truly with thee." (Josh 2:12-14)

They arranged a signal, using a scarlet thread: "Behold, when we come into the land, thou shalt bind this line of scarlet thread in the window which thou didst let us down by: and thou shalt bring thy father, and thy mother, and thy brethren, and all thy father's household, home unto thee. {19} And it shall be, that whosoever shall go out of the doors of thy house into the street, his blood shall be upon his head, and we will be guiltless: and whosoever shall be with thee in the house, his blood shall be on our head, if any hand be upon him. {20} And if thou utter this our business, then we will be quit of thine oath which thou hast made us to swear. {21} And she said, According unto your words, so be it. And she sent them away, and they departed: and she bound the scarlet line in the window." (Josh 2:18-21)

When the city was taken, only Rachab and her family were saved: "And it came to pass at the seventh time, when the priests blew with the trumpets, Joshua said unto the people, Shout; for the LORD hath given you the city. {17} And the city shall be accursed, even it, and all that are therein, to the LORD: only Rachab the harlot shall live, she and all that are with her in the house, because she hid the messengers that we sent." (Josh 6:16-17)

The scarlet thread points to the blood of Christ, which saves us from all sin, and protects all households that cleave unto Him. Rachab was a harlot who was made clean. Boaz took her to wife, indicating in a mystical way how Christ makes all things clean, and renews human nature. Of course, the holy Chrysostom says it best: "Seest thou that it was not for few nor

small causes that he brought to our remembrance the whole history concerning Judah? For this end he hath mentioned Ruth also and Rachab, the one an alien, the other an harlot, that thou mayest learn that He came to do away with all our ills. For He hath come as a Physician, not as a Judge. Therefore in like manner as those of old took harlots for wives, even so God too espoused unto Himself the nature which had played the harlot..." (Chrysostom, Homilies on Matthew, Homily 5, section 5)

ANSWER 9. Ruth was a foreigner, from land of Moab, a pagan land. She was the daughter in law of Naomi, whose son she had married, and was left a widow at a young age. Naomi and her two daughters in law, Ruth and Oprah, journeyed from Moab into the land of Judah.

Naomi, who was an Israelite, asked her daughters in law to return back to their land: "And Naomi said unto her two daughters in law, Go, return each to her mother's house: the LORD deal kindly with you, as ye have dealt with the dead, and with me. {9} The LORD grant you that ye may find rest, each of you in the house of her husband. Then she kissed them; and they lifted up their voice, and wept." (Ruth 1:8-9)

They with one voice demurred, but Naomi persisted, and broke the resolve of Oprah, who went to return to her own people in Moab: "And they said unto her, Surely we will return with thee unto thy people. {11} And Naomi said, Turn again, my daughters: why will ye go with me? Are there yet any more sons in my womb, that they may be your husbands? {12} Turn again, my daughters, go your way; for I am too old to have a husband. If I should say, I have hope, if I should have an husband also to night, and should also bear sons; {13} Would ye tarry for them till they were grown? Would ye stay for them from having husbands? nay, my daughters; for it grieveth me much for your sakes that the hand of the LORD is gone out against me. {14} And they lifted up their voice, and wept again: and Oprah kissed her mother in law; but Ruth clave unto her." (Ruth 1:10-14)

Ruth was steadfast in her resolve, amazing Naomi. Ruth passionately declared her belief in the true God, and her fidelity to him. Do not her words stir the blood, even now?

"And she said, Behold, thy sister in law is gone back unto her people, and unto her gods: return thou after thy sister in law. {16} And Ruth said, Entreat me not to leave thee, or to return from following after thee: for whither thou goest, I will go; and where thou lodgest, I will lodge: thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God: {17} Where thou diest, will I die, and there will I be buried: the LORD do so to me, and more also, if ought but death part thee and me." (Ruth 1:15-17)

Ruth and Naomi went to Jerusalem, where they were so poor they needed to glean the leftover wheat from the fields. God rewarded her steadfast faith, expressed not only in words, but also deeds, and found the stranger and pilgrim Ruth a husband.

"And Ruth the Moabitess said unto Naomi, Let me now go to the field, and glean ears of corn after him in whose sight I shall find grace. And she said unto her, Go, my daughter." (Ruth 2:2)

Boaz saw her, and was kind to her. "Then said Boaz unto his servant that was set over the reapers, Whose damsel is this? {6} And the servant that was set over the reapers answered and said, It is the Moabitish damsel that came back with Naomi out of the country of Moab: {7} And she said, I pray you, let me glean and gather after the reapers among the sheaves: so she came, and hath continued even from the morning until now, that she tarried a little in the house. {8} Then said Boaz unto Ruth, Hearst thou not, my daughter? Go not to glean in another field, neither go from hence, but abide here fast by my maidens: {9} Let thine eyes be on the field that they do reap, and go thou after them: have I not charged the young men that they shall not touch thee? and when thou art athirst, go unto the vessels, and drink of that which the young men have drawn. {10} Then she fell on her face, and bowed herself to the ground, and said unto him, Why have I found grace in thine eyes, that thou shouldest take knowledge of me,

seeing I am a stranger? {11} And Boaz answered and said unto her, It hath fully been showed me, all that thou hast done unto thy mother in law since the death of thine husband: and how thou hast left thy father and thy mother, and the land of thy nativity, and art come unto a people which thou knewest not heretofore. {12} The LORD recompense thy work, and a full reward be given thee of the LORD God of Israel, under whose wings thou art come to trust." (Ruth 2:5-12)

To make a long and compellingly beautiful story a little shorter, Boaz took Ruth to wife, and out of this union, born of fidelity and honor, and kindness, came forth Obed, who was the father of Jesse, who was the father of David the king:

"So Boaz took Ruth, and she was his wife: and when he went in unto her, the LORD gave her conception, and she bare a son. {14} And the women said unto Naomi, Blessed be the LORD, which hath not left thee this day without a kinsman, that his name may be famous in Israel. {15} And he shall be unto thee a restorer of thy life, and a nourisher of thine old age: for thy daughter in law, which loveth thee, which is better to thee than seven sons, hath borne him. {16} And Naomi took the child, and laid it in her bosom, and became nurse unto it. {17} And the women her neighbors gave it a name, saying, There is a son born to Naomi; and they called his name Obed: he is the father of Jesse, the father of David." (Ruth 4:13-17)

Although the answer is again become long, we cannot leave off the inspired words of the Holy Chrysostom, who aids us in marveling at the economy of God: "See, for instance, what befell Ruth, how like it is to the things which belong to us. For she was both of a strange race, and reduced

to the utmost poverty, yet Boaz when he saw her neither despised her poverty nor abhorred her mean birth, as Christ having received the Church, being both an alien and in much poverty, took her to be partaker of the great blessings. But even as Ruth, if she had not before left her father, and renounced household and race, country and kindred, would not have attained unto this alliance; so the Church too, having forsaken the customs which men had received from their fathers, then, and not before, became lovely to the Bridegroom. Of this therefore the prophet discourses unto her, and saith, "Forget thy people, and thy father's house, so shall the king have pleasure in thy beauty." This Ruth did too, and because of this she became a mother of kings, even as the Church did likewise. For of her David himself sprung. So then to shame them by all these things, and to prevail on them not to be high-minded, he hath both composed the genealogy, and brought forward these women." (Homilies on Matthew, Homily 3, Section 5)

ANSWER 10. The former wife of Urias was Bathsheba. She was a beautiful woman, whom David saw bathing, while he was reclining in idleness. He lusted for her, and committed adultery, and was so taken with her that he arranged for her husband Urias, who was in battle, to be put at the front, so that he was killed. Thus was David guilty of both adultery and murder. Eventually, out of their union came Solomon, who continued the line of Christ.

How inscrutable are God's ways! How great is His condescension! The God-man counts as his ancestors harlots and strangers, and adulterers and murderers. Can there be any doubt that there is no sin too great for His mercy to cover?

Answers to Questions about the parable of the Great Supper

ANSWER 1 This parable is read on the Sunday of the Holy Forefathers. This is 2 Sundays before the Nativity of the Savior. The parable speaks of the incarnation, in a profound way, and is a fitting preparation for the celebration of it.

ANSWER 2 "And when one of them that sat at meat with him heard these things, he said unto him, Blessed is he that shall eat bread in the kingdom of God. (Luke 14:15)

The holy Fathers explain that Christ was answering the man and teaching what it means to feast with God.

ANSWER 3. The "man" is God the Father. God is referred to as a man when His love for mankind is emphasized. When His power to punish is alluded to, He is called panther, a leopard, or a bear. (See St John Chrysostom, and Hos 13:7-8)

ANSWER 4. The Great Supper is God's great economy to man, accomplished through the incarnation. Through the incarnation, we become sharers of Christ's flesh and therefore able the feast with him, and be the blessed ones who eat bread in the kingdom of God"

It is a supper and not a dinner because our Lord came in the last days; supper is the evening meal. This was foreshadowed by the time of day that the Paschal (Passover) lamb was slain, according to the Mosaic Law; in the evening.

ANSWER 5. The servant is Christ. Supper time is the appointed and proper time.

The two callings are this: those that were bidden are the Jews, who were told of Christ through the law and the prophets. Christ Himself accomplished the second calling.

ANSWER 6. Both represent the love of wealth, and material things. This love blinds a man to the higher, spiritual things. A carnal man cannot comprehend spiritual things.

The piece of ground, or "farm", especially "signifies the man who cannot accept the mystery of faith because he is governed by the wisdom of this world" (Bl. Theofylact)

The ground represents the world, and nature. The man who must go and see his ground sees only nature. He cannot accept spiritual things, such as the birth of Christ from a virgin, the incarnation, turning the other cheek, and in general the entire Christian teaching.

The man who bought the 5 yoke of oxen and tested them represents he who loves material things. He uses his 5 senses foolishly, and with them yokes his soul to the world, with its love of pleasure and lusts. This man also does not understand earthly things, because his mind is ever turned earthward, since oxen are used to till the ground.

ANSWER 7. The wife is a metaphor for the inordinate attachment to the flesh, and pleasures. Just as a wife is the mate of the husband, the flesh is the mate of the soul. One who cleaves to the flesh cannot please God.

Note well that it is not the marrying of a wife that is condemned, but the putting of a wife (fleshly pleasures) above God ("therefore I cannot come").

ANSWER 8. This parable was surely aimed at the Jews who rejected the servant who came at suppertime, Jesus Christ.

It also applies to every soul, whether he be Orthodox or not, who is attached to earthly things and pleasures or does not have true, living faith in God. Every man is called to the Great supper by his conscience.

ANSWER 9 The poor are those blessed ones who are poor in spirit, that is, humble, and willing to hear and obey the message of the Gospel. Such ones may have many spiritual and physical defects, but none of things will keep a man from the Kingdom of God if he believes.

The halt are those who do not follow an upright journey throughout life. They are like a man who cannot walk in a straight path because of his infirmity. Such ones can be made completely whole and be able to walk again, if they heed the spiritual words of the Gospel.

Those who are blind have no brightness in their minds. They too can be enlightened, when they accept the light which illuminates them.

ANSWER 10. With these words the Lord indicates the calling of the Gentiles. The Jews were also halt and blind, but within the "city", that is, they were those whom the Lord came to first. The Gentiles were outside the city, in the hedges and highways

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Answers to Questions about the Gospel of Matthew Chapter 2

ANSWER 1. Bethlehem means "House of bread".

And Jesus said unto them, I am the bread of life: he that cometh to me shall never hunger; and he that believeth on me shall never thirst. [John 6:35]

Rightly is He born in Bethlehem, which signifies the house of bread, who said, "I am the living bread, who came down from heaven." [Gregory, Hom. in Evan., 8, 1]

ANSWER 2. Herod was not of the line of Judah, but was an Idumean, the son of Antipater, an Arab woman. He was King because of bribing the Roman government. Since the king of Israel was not from the line of Judah (an event that had never happened before), and Jesus was born during his reign, an important prophecy, known to all pious Jews, was fulfilled:

"The Sceptre shall not depart from Judah, nor a Lawgiver from between his feet, until Shiloh come. [Gen 49:10]

Since Matthew was primarily trying to convince Jews concerning Jesus, he mentions the historical details that prove the prophesy.

"Herod was an Idumaeon, of noble birth, and that his father Antipas was governor of Idumaea under Alexander Jannaeus.] He was instructed in the law and customs of the Jews, and acquired the friendship of Hyrcanus, king of Judaea, who sent him as his deputy to Pompey. He succeeded so well in the object of his mission, that he laid claim to a share of the throne. He was put to death, but his son Herod was under Antony appointed king of Judaea, by a decree of the Senate; so it is clear that Herod sought the throne of Judaea without any connection or claim of birth. " [Euseb. Hist. i. 7. Antiq. xiv. 1. n. 3. de Bell. Jud. i. 6. n. 2., quoted in the Catena Aurea]

ANSWER 3 It is most probable that the Magi were descendants of Balaam, who having his prophecy, "There shall rise a Star out of Jacob," [Num 24:17] as soon as they saw the star, would know that a King was born.

"Behold the Man whose name is the East." [Zechariah 6:12]

ANSWER 4. What were these Magi but the first fruits of the Gentiles? Israelitish shepherds, gentile Magians, one from far, the other from near, hastened to the one Corner-stone. [Aug., Sermon. 202. Sermon. 202, quoted in the Catena Aurea]

ANSWER 5. The "star" was not a naturally occurring star, but an Angel.

The Magi followed it - from North, in Persia, to Jerusalem, which is South. In the Northern Hemisphere, stars never move from North to South.

They saw the star by day. Travel at night was difficult and risky.

When they arrived at Jerusalem, the star disappeared from their sight. This is evident because of their inquiries, which would not have been needed if the star had continued to guide them, and their "exceeding great joy", when the star reappeared:

When they had heard the king, they departed; and, lo, the star, which they saw in the east, went before them, till it came and stood over where

the young child was. {10} When they saw the star, they rejoiced with exceeding great joy. [Mat 2:9-10]

When they arrived in Bethlehem, the star stood over where the young child was, that is, it descended from the heavens to point out the house where the family was living.

No natural star shines during the day, or moves from North to the South, let alone moving at will and to pointing out a location. This star was an Angel.

This was manifestly not one of the common stars of Heaven. First, because none of the stars moves in this way, from east to south, and such is the situation of Palestine with respect to Persia. Secondly, from the time of its appearance, not in the night only, but during the day. Thirdly, from its being visible and then again invisible; when they entered Jerusalem it hid itself, and then appeared again when they left Herod. Further, it had no stated motion, but when the Magi were to go on, it went before them; when to stop, it stopped like the pillar of cloud in the desert. Fourthly, it signified the Virgin's delivery, not by being fixed aloft, but by descending to earth, shewing herein like an invisible virtue formed into the visible appearance of a star. [St John Chrysostom]

ANSWER 6 By God.' providence the star, that is, the angel, hid itself for a little while, forcing the Magi to make inquiries. The inquiries showed the true nature of the Jews, and their hardness of heart and unbelief.

The star that guided the Magi to the spot where was the Infant God with His Virgin Mother, might have conducted them straight to the town; but it vanished, and shewed not itself again to them till the Jews themselves had told them "the place where Christ should be born;" Bethlehem of Judaea. [Aug., Sermon. 374. 2, 373. 4]

The Magi, judging as men, sought in the royal city for Him, whom they had been told was born a King. But He who took the form of a servant, and came not to judge but to be judged, chose Bethlehem for His birth, Jerusalem for His death. [Leo, Sermon. 31, 2]

ANSWER 7 Herod was a foreigner, a so-called "client king". His hold on power was tenuous, and he could be replaced by any clever fellow with enough money to sway the allegiance of Rome. He was therefore paranoid about any real or imagined threats to his power.

As the Magi seek a Redeemer, so Herod fears a successor. [Blessed Augustine]

At the birth of a King of Heaven, a king of earth is troubled; surely, earthly greatness is confounded, when heavenly greatness shews itself. [Gregory, Hom. in Evan., 1, 10]

ANSWER 8 But thou, Bethlehem Ephratah, though thou be little among the thousands of Judah, yet out of thee shall he come forth unto me that is to be ruler in Israel; whose goings forth have been from of old, from everlasting. [Micah 5:1]

The scribes changed the quotation slightly for Herod, so he would understand it better.

ANSWER 9 Jesus was born in Bethlehem, but grew up in Nazareth.

Observe the exactness of the prophecy; it is not He shall be in Bethlehem, but shall come out of Bethlehem; shewing that He should be only born there. What reason is there for applying this to Zorobabel, as some do? For his goings forth were not from everlasting; nor did he go forth from Bethlehem, but was born in Babylonia. The expression, "art not the least," is a further proof, for none but Christ could make the town where He was born illustrious. [St John Chrysostom]

The following is the sense of the prophecy. Thou, Bethlehem, of the land of Judah, or Ephrata, (which is added to distinguish it from another Bethlehem in Galilee,) though thou art a small village among the thousand cities of Judah, yet out of thee shall be born Christ, who shall be the Ruler of Israel, who according to the flesh is of the seed of David, but was born of Me before the worlds; and therefore it is written, "His goings forth are of old. In the beginning was the Word." [St Jerome, in Mich. v. 2]

ANSWER 10 Our Lord Jesus Christ was born in a cave, a manger for animals. Since the Magi worshipped him in a house, they obviously did not see him on the day of his birth, Christmas Nativity scenes notwithstanding!

ANSWER 11 • Gold - for a king

- Frankincense - as befitting God
- Myrrh - forefiguring His burial

Gold, as to a King; frankincense, as sacrifice to God; myrrh, as embalming the body of the dead. [Greg., Hom. in Evan., 1, 106]

Gold, as paid to a mighty King; frankincense, as offered to God; myrrh, as to one who is to die for the sins of all. [Blessed Augustine]

Something further may yet be meant here. Wisdom is typified by gold; as Solomon saith in the Proverbs, "A treasure to be desired is in the mouth of the wise." [Greg]

By frankincense, which is burnt before God, the power of prayer [p. 77] is intended, as in the Psalms, "Let my speech come before thee as incense." [Ps 141:2] In myrrh is figured mortification of the flesh. To a king at his birth we offer gold, if we shine in his sight with the light of wisdom; we offer frankincense, if we have power before God by the sweet savour of our prayers; we offer myrrh, when we mortify by abstinence the lusts of the flesh. [Greg]

Psalms 72:1 Give the king thy judgments, O God, and thy righteousness unto the king's son. 2 He shall judge thy people with righteousness, and thy poor with judgment. 3 The mountains shall bring peace to the people, and the little hills, by righteousness. 4 He shall judge the poor of the people, he shall save the children of the needy, and shall break in pieces the oppressor. 5 They shall fear thee as long as the sun and moon endure, throughout all generations. 6 He shall come down like rain upon the mown grass: as showers that water the earth. 7 In his days shall the righteous flourish; and abundance of peace so long as the moon endureth. 8 He shall have dominion also from sea to sea, and from the river unto the ends of the earth. 9 They that dwell in the wilderness shall bow before him; and his enemies shall lick the dust. 10 The kings of Tarshish and of the isles shall bring presents: the kings of Sheba and Seba shall offer gifts.

Isaiah 60:1 Arise, shine; for thy light is come, and the glory of the LORD is risen upon thee. 2 For, behold, the darkness shall cover the earth, and gross darkness the people: but the LORD shall arise upon thee, and his glory shall be seen upon thee. 3 And the Gentiles shall come to thy light, and kings to the brightness of thy rising. 4 Lift up thine eyes round about, and see: all they gather themselves together, they come to thee: thy sons

shall come from far, and thy daughters shall be nursed at thy side. 5 Then thou shalt see, and flow together, and thine heart shall fear, and be enlarged; because the abundance of the sea shall be converted unto thee, the forces of the Gentiles shall come unto thee. 6 The multitude of camels shall cover thee, the dromedaries of Midian and Ephah; all they from Sheba shall come: they shall bring gold and incense; and they shall shew forth the praises of the LORD.

ANSWER 12 The Magi returned another way in order to avoid Herod.

We may learn much from this return of the Magi another way. Our country is Paradise, to which, after we have come to the knowledge of Christ we are forbidden to return the way we came. We have left this country by pride, disobedience, following things of sight, tasting, forbidden food; and we must return to it by repentance, obedience, by contemning things of sight, and overcoming carnal appetite. [Greg., Hom. in Ev. i. 10. 7]

ANSWER 13 When Israel was a child, then I loved him, and called my son out of Egypt [Hosea 11:1]

The burden of Egypt. Behold, the LORD rideth upon a swift cloud, and shall come into Egypt: and the idols of Egypt shall be moved at his presence, and the heart of Egypt shall melt in the midst of it. [Isaiah 19:1]

ANSWER 14 O blessed infants! He only will doubt of your crown in this your passion for Christ, who doubts that the baptism of Christ has a benefit for infants. He who at His birth had Angels to proclaim Him, the heavens to testify, and Magi to worship Him, could surely have prevented that these should not have died for Him, had He not known that they died not in that death, but rather lived in higher bliss. Far be the thought, that Christ who came to set men free, did nothing to reward those who died in His behalf, when hanging on the cross He prayed for those who put Him to death. [Aug., Sermon. 373, 3]

In this death of the children the precious death of all Christ's martyrs is figured; that they were infants signifies, that by the merit of humility alone can we come to the glory of martyrdom; that they were slain in Bethlehem and the coasts thereof, that the persecution shall be both in Jerusalem whence the Church originated, and throughout the world; in those of two years old are figured the perfect in doctrine and works; those under that age the neophytes; that they were slain while Christ escaped, signifies that the bodies of the martyrs may be destroyed by the wicked, but that Christ cannot be taken from them. [Bede, Hom. in Nat. Innocent]

Revelation 12: 1 And there appeared a great wonder in heaven; a woman clothed with the sun, and the moon under her feet, and upon her head a crown of twelve stars: 2 And she being with child cried, travailing in birth, and pained to be delivered. 3 And there appeared another wonder in heaven; and behold a great red dragon, having seven heads and ten horns, and seven crowns upon his heads. 4 And his tail drew the third part of the stars of heaven, and did cast them to the earth: and the dragon stood before the woman which was ready to be delivered, for to devour her child as soon as it was born. 5 And she brought forth a man child, who was to rule all nations with a rod of iron: and her child was caught up unto God, and to his throne. 6 And the woman fled into the wilderness, where she hath a place prepared of God, that they should feed her there a thousand two hundred and threescore days.

ANSWER 15 This passage of Jeremiah has been quoted by Matthew neither according to the Hebrew nor the LXX version. This shews that the [p. 84] Evangelists and Apostles did not follow any one's translation, but according to the Hebrew manner expressed in their own words what they had read in Hebrew.

By Ramah we need not suppose that the town of that name near Gibeah is meant; but take it as signifying 'high.' A voice was heard 'aloft,' that is, spread far and wide. [Jerome, In Hierem, 31, 15]

Rachel's son was Benjamin, in which tribe Bethlehem is not situated. How then does Rachel weep for the children of Judah as if they were her own? We answer briefly. She was buried near Bethlehem in Ephrata, and was regarded as the mother, because her body was there entertained. Or, as the two tribes of Judah and Benjamin were contiguous, and Herod's command extended to the coasts of Bethlehem as well as to the town itself, we may suppose that many were slain in Benjamin. [Jerome]

ANSWER 16 The text of this prophesy is nowhere found in Scripture, but the Jews absolutely believed in it's sense, as the following scripture show:

[Mat 21:11] And the multitude said, This is Jesus the prophet of Nazareth of Galilee.

[Mat 26:71] And when he was gone out into the porch, another maid saw him, and said unto them that were there, This fellow was also with Jesus of Nazareth.

[Mark 1:24] Saying, Let us alone; what have we to do with thee, thou Jesus of Nazareth? art thou come to destroy us? I know thee who thou art, the Holy One of God.

[Mark 10:47] And when he heard that it was Jesus of Nazareth, he began to cry out, and say, Jesus, thou son of David, have mercy on me.

[Mark 14:67] And when she saw Peter warming himself, she looked upon him, and said, And thou also wast with Jesus of Nazareth.

[Mark 16:6] And he saith unto them, Be not affrighted: Ye seek Jesus of Nazareth, which was crucified: he is risen; he is not here: behold the place where they laid him.

[Luke 4:34] Saying, Let us alone; what have we to do with thee, thou Jesus of Nazareth? art thou come to destroy us? I know thee who thou art; the Holy One of God.

[Luke 18:37] And they told him, that Jesus of Nazareth passeth by.

[Luke 24:19] And he said unto them, What things? And they said unto him, Concerning Jesus of Nazareth, which was a prophet mighty in deed and word before God and all the people:

[John 1:45-46] Philip findeth Nathanael, and saith unto him, We have found him, of whom Moses in the law, and the prophets, did write, Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph. {46} And Nathanael said unto him, Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth? Philip saith unto him, Come and see.

[John 19:19] And Pilate wrote a title, and put it on the cross. And the writing was, JESUS OF NAZARETH THE KING OF THE JEWS.

[Acts 2:22] Ye men of Israel, hear these words; Jesus of Nazareth, a man approved of God among you by miracles and wonders and signs, which God did by him in the midst of you, as ye yourselves also know:

[Acts 3:6] Then Peter said, Silver and gold have I none; but such as I have give I thee: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth rise up and walk.

[Acts 4:10] Be it known unto you all, and to all the people of Israel, that by the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, whom ye crucified, whom God raised from the dead, even by him doth this man stand here before you whole.

Had he meant to quote a particular text, he would not have written 'Prophets,' but 'the Prophet.' By thus using the plural he evidently [p. 90] does not take the words of any one passage in Scripture, but the sense of the whole. Nazarene is interpreted, 'Holy,' and that the Lord would be Holy, all Scripture testifies.

Otherwise we may explain that it is found in Isaiah rendered to the strict letter of the Hebrew. "There shall come a Rod out of the stem of Jesse, and a Nazarene [branch] shall grow out of His roots." [Isa 11:1] [St erome]